

THE EYES OF AISHA

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*Ihuoma Iroaganachi*

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**BY**

**Ihuoma Iroaganachi**

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PRODUCTION

# The Eyes of Aisha

Ihuoma Iroaganachi @ 2025

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## DEDICATION

Dedicated to every young woman who has faced adversity and triumphed.

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## Chapter One

The early harmattan breeze blew across the quiet village of Gantu sending a wave of dust across the stretch of scattered mud houses. The raffia rooftops were painted with dust. The ground was hard and crusty. The residents of Gantu were yet to stir from sleep. The biting cold was especially severe that morning. The sun was up but did nothing to lessen the cold.

Aisha got up from the mat she slept on and rubbed her eyes. She had been up since the first call to prayer but did not stir. Her mother and her aunt lay on the mat to her left while her four younger siblings huddled together on the mat to her right. The room was bare except for a cupboard that housed different color of enamel plates. Two big bags beside the cupboard were stuffed with her clothes and that of her siblings. She looked at her aunty again to see if she was awake. Both were traveling to the city today. Aisha could hardly contain her excitement. She had never left the village of Gantu since she was born. She had never boarded a car before and only dreamed of riding in one, until two days ago, her aunty turned up and announced she was taking her along to the city to stay with her. The new dress her aunty bought for her was spread neatly on top of one of the bags.

Aisha firmly tied the wrapper she slept in around her chest and stood up. Despite the cold, the wrapper around her body was the only clothing she slept in. She went to the door and opened it. A wave of dust and sunlight swept into the room and over her making her eyes misty.

"Shut the door,

Aisha." Her mother said sharply. "What are you doing up at this time of the morning?"

"Mama it's dawn, the sun is up, and everybody is still sleeping. I want to go and feed the cows."

"When did you start feeding the cows? Dan Allah shut the door".

Aisha turned to look behind her, Aunty Meimuna sat on the mat rubbing her eyes. She smiled secretly. She has achieved her aim.

"Aunty Meimuna, when are we leaving for the city? It's already morning."

"I thought I heard you say you want to feed the cows."

"I will go and feed them and dress up so we can leave."

"Not so fast Aisha, leave the feeding of the cows to your father. Let's go and prepare breakfast. We must eat before we leave. The city is far from here and you know, we have a long distance to walk to where we will catch a bus to the city".

"Yes, aunty Meimuna."

Aisha walked into the courtyard and stretched her body. She was five feet tall, already too tall for her twelve years. She had white patches on her chocolate-coloured skin because of the harsh weather. Her legs were straight, and her shoulder was square and firm. She had round big black eyes that sparkled with joy and excitement.

Aisha entered the small hut that served as a kitchen and set about making fire to warm the left-over rice and mia kuka sauce, and to boil water for bathing. She was adept at her regular morning chore. She swept out the ashes in between the three big stones that served as a tripod stand, put dried sticks and dried leaves in between the openings struck the match, the fire came up immediately, she put the pot of soup on the fire and sat down to watch it boil and to warm her body. She put both palms on her cheeks with her elbow resting on her thighs and closed her eyes to dream about the city.

When her aunt, Meimuna, arrived at their home two days back and announced that she would be leaving with her to the city, she had bombarded her with questions about what the city looked like. She imagined herself riding in a bus, she saw herself arriving in the city where there were beautiful brick houses with electric lights. Her aunt had tried to describe what electric light was. She imagined little cylindrical shaped containers with lights inside them illuminating the whole room.

"Aisha, are you inside the kitchen and the soup is burning?"

Aisha snapped out of her reverie and quickly brought down the pot with her bare hands, hissing as it scalded her palms. Next, she warmed the rice, put the pot of water on the fire to boil, and left the kitchen.

She re-entered the room where her mother and Meimuna sat talking. They stopped talking as she came in. She went back into the kitchen and brought the food for all of them. Aisha and all her siblings ate from the same bowl while her mother and aunt ate together in another bowl. At the end of the meal, she went out and hurriedly took her bath and dressed up with her new dress, ready to go.

Aisha and her aunt, accompanied by her mother and siblings walked all the way through the uneven track road from the village to the main highway to wait for a bus. By the time they came to the road, their feet were dusty. Meimuna cleaned her feet and that of Aisha and tried to make them look presentable.

"May Allah grant you a safe journey."

"Amin. We will visit during the holidays."

"May God keep us till then."

"Aisha be a good girl in the city."

"Yes, mama," Aisha replied with her eyes on the road. She could hardly wait to leave.

A bus came by, and they boarded to get to the main bus terminal to the city. Aisha and her aunt sat close to the big bus window on their way to Abuja. Some passengers were discussing in low tones. Aisha listened to some of the discussions in the Hausa language but could not understand the language spoken by a few of the passengers.

"Aunty, what language are some of these people speaking?"

"It is the English language; English is the language everyone speaks in the city to be able to communicate with each other."

"It sounds strange."

"Don't worry, you will soon learn the English language."

Aisha smiled with growing excitement. She would also learn a new language. she would love the challenge of learning a new language. She started listening attentively to the people speaking English, though she could not make head or tail out of what was being said.



## Chapter Two

As they arrived in the city of Abuja, Aisha was awed by what she saw. She had slept through some of the smaller towns and cities they passed along the way but woke up at the nudging of her aunt as they arrived in Abuja. Her eyes darted this way and that as she stared at both sides of the road. There were tall, big buildings everywhere. The rooftops were of different sizes, colours and designs. She wanted to ask so many questions but could not say a word. She took in the surroundings speechless with wonder and joy. This was her new city. Aisha made a promise to herself to make Abuja her permanent home. She would live in this city for the rest of her life.

They boarded a smaller bus to the district where Meimuna lived with her husband.

Meimuna's husband, Musa, was a gateman in the house of Mr. Ogaran. Musa came to Abuja with his friends in search of menial jobs. After several years of working as a helping hand at construction sites, he got a job as a gatekeeper in Mr. Ogaran's house, he went home and married Meimuna and brought her with him to the city. They had a daughter Zainab.

Mr. Ogaran, the Deputy Director of Research at the Federal Ministry of Health, lives in a four-bedroom duplex at the government estate in the city. His house was one of the prototype houses built on the estate for top government officials. Each house was built with a small one-room apartment close to the gate that served as living quarters for the security men. Meimuna's husband lived in Mr. Ogaran's gatehouse. Meimuna and Aisha walked the short distance from the bus stop to the estate. Mr. Ogaran's house was on number No.2 Minna Street in Garden Estate. Meimuna knocked at the gate once and her husband opened the gate for them to come in. Aisha greeted her uncle on bended knees. She had only seen him once before. He responded with a slight smile and a nod.

The one-room gatehouse was sparsely furnished with a bed, one armchair and a table. A television set was on the table at one end of the

room. Aisha wanted to ask what that was for but decided against it. She will soon find out anyway. They quickly unpacked and set about cooking supper. When it got dark, Meimuna switched on the light and Aisha blinked severally before her eyes adjusted to the bright light. She always imagined the wonder of electricity, now that she saw it her first reaction was a slight shock, though it was momentary. She looked up at the fluorescent bulb and blinked again. She got up and took a peep outside, the whole compound was lit up. She went close to the gate and peeped through an opening at the gate, everywhere as far as her eyes could see was lit up. Excitement and joy welled up inside her. For the second time that day, she vowed to herself she would always live in the city. This was where she belonged. After supper, Musa went out to sit by the gate and Meimuna turned on the Television. Aisha got confused, she looked from her Aunt to the TV and back.

“Whom are these people talking and where are they?”

Before Meimuna could answer, Aisha went to the back of the TV to see if some people were hiding at the back. It did not make sense, if there were other people in the room, she could have seen them anyway. Meimuna laughed for a while as she remembered her reaction to seeing a television set a few years ago. She had limited knowledge of electronics, the little she knew was what her husband told her which was equally limited.

“Come and sit Aisha and I will tell you how the TV works.”

She tried to explain what she knew about television which was totally lost on Aisha. She could only take in so much information in one day.

“You know Aisha, I don’t think it is possible you’ll learn about everything in one day, you will get to understand it as time goes on.”

“Where are all these people, are they in this small box?”

“Aisha, your uncle will tell you all about it tomorrow, just be quiet and let’s watch the drama.”

She sat beside her aunt on the mat and leaned back on the wall enthralled with everything that was going on around her. Soon after, she lay on the mat and fell asleep, Meimuna lay Zainab on the mat beside Aisha.

Early the next morning Aisha woke up as soon as her aunty did and was told to sweep the compound. As she swept, she stayed on the alert to see the owners of the house who lived in the big house so she could practice the first English phrase her aunty had been teaching her for the past thirty minutes they had been up. As soon as Mr. Ogaran and his wife walked out of their house to the car garage, Aisha greeted them from the gatehouse raising her voice. "Gidi morni sah, gidi morni ma."

Mr. Ogaran and his wife turned in the direction of the voice.

"Good morning, how are you?"

Aisha hesitated, trying to remember the next phrase, but could not, she smiled instead. Meimuna greeted the Ogarans as they smiled at Aisha.

"Dis na my sista pickin Aisha, I come back from village wit am."

"Okay, your niece, Musa told me you'd come back with your niece."

"Yessah, we don come."

"Good, she looks like a smart kid. Welcome to Abuja, Aisha."

Aisha smiled at the mention of her name, without understanding what was being said. She quickly made up her mind that the fastest way to learn this new language was to try and mimic whatever her aunty says to the Ogarans or any other person for that matter. As the Ogarans drove off to their office, Aisha turned to her aunty.

"Where are their children?"

"They don't have any child yet."

"You mean no child, no children?"

"That's what I just said."

"Where are the other wives of the Megida?"

"He has only one wife."

"He has only one wife and no children, why has he not married other wives?"

"He doesn't want to marry other wives, and their religion tells them to marry only one wife."

"I have not seen any man who has only one wife."

"Aisha I am the only wife of my husband."

"But Aunty Meimuna Uncle Musa will marry another wife any time he wants to do so. All the men in the village have more than one wife."

"Now shut up Aisha and go and light up the stove."

Aisha noticed that her comment made her aunty angry without knowing why. She followed her into the tiny kitchen to learn how to light a stove. There was so much to learn in the city.

Aisha spent the better part of the day chanting the new greeting her aunty taught her.

“Gidi morni sah, Gidi morni ma”

“Welicome sah, welicome ma”

“How are you?”

“Fine sah, fine ma.”

Meimuna’s three-year-old daughter Zainab joined in the chant, and it soon turned into a danceable rhythm.

Early the next morning, Aisha was waiting for the Ogarans to put her knowledge into practice. This time around she got the greetings correct and Mr. Ogaran was impressed. Later in the day she stood by the gate and greeted passersby walking up or down the street. It became her routine to practice any new word or phrase she learned with the people who passed by the gate. Most of them laughed at her blunders and mix-ups, and within a short time, she became popular with the people who lived on Minna Street.

Three weeks later, Meimuna took Aisha to the Estate primary school to enrol her for the academic year that just started. Aisha was shown to her new classroom, class 2B. The pupils in the class sat on chairs and desks, and Aisha felt like jumping up with joy. She went and sat on her chair and desk with twenty pairs of eyes staring at her. She was the oldest in the class, but she did not notice. She was demoted two classes behind because she could neither read nor write the questions on her placement test paper for primary four. The English language used on the test paper was way beyond her. She understood most of the questions that were explained to her by the teacher but could not write the answers. She sat on her chair, put her hands on the desk and looked around, and smiled at her fellow pupils. For the first time in her life, she was sitting on a chair behind a desk to learn and study. The only classroom she has known was the shade under the mango tree in Gantu. The only person who sat on a chair behind the desk was the class teacher, the rest of them sat on the bare ground.

Aisha learned fast, studied hard and came top of her class by the end of the term. Three years later, her class teacher encouraged her aunty to register her for the state common entrance examination into secondary school, though she still had a year to finish primary school, Meimuna did so and Aisha promised her she would pass the examination.

### Chapter Three

Ekaete swept the tiny space in front of their house. Her five other siblings were still fast asleep, some on the floor and some on the six-inch bed by the wall of the room. The children slept in one room, while their parents slept in the other room. She lived with her parents in a one-bedroom apartment in the inner city of Abuja. She was told she was only two years old when her parents came to live in the city. Today will be the last time she would be sweeping the courtyard at least for a while. Her mother had arranged a job dealing with a couple in Lagos on her behalf. They would pay her a monthly salary, which her mother would collect on her behalf to enable her husband to feed and pay the school fees for her younger siblings.

Ekaete expected the couple with mixed feelings. On the one hand, she was happy she will be able to help her younger siblings have a better life and that she was leaving the squalor of poverty to taste something of a better life, hopefully, on the other hand, she was leaving the comfort and love of her home for whatever it was worth, to go and serve others as a house help. She knew that a maid was hardly treated as a daughter. Girls her age were still attending school and taken care of by their parents and not the other way around, she had learned to accept her fate and count her blessings. Some other girls in her neighbourhood had gone off as house helps at a much younger age. Her dresses were packed in a black polythene bag, she would wear her school uniform and sandals which was the best piece of clothing she had.

After sweeping, she boiled water on the rickety stove beside their house and took her bath, got dressed, and sat down to wait. There was no breakfast to prepare. The loaf of bread the whole family shared the night before was hardly enough for two persons and her stomach was rumbling with hunger. Ekaete and her family lived on one meal a day.

Her only brother Eno came out from the room and picked up his ball and went outside to play, her three other sisters came out and sat beside her on the bench. Nobody else cared to take a bath since there was no school for the day. Their mother who had gone out early in the

morning to attend morning mass walked back briskly to the house. She was a slim fair woman who always seemed to be in a hurry. She had a sprightly step and did everything in a hurry. Ekaete sometimes wondered why her beautiful mother married a pauper like her father. Her mother dropped out of school while she was still in junior secondary school and her father was illiterate. Her father worked as a 'water man' in a horticultural firm a long distance from the house. He leaves early in the morning and comes back when they had all slept. Sometimes the younger children didn't see him for two or three straight days. They probably would not have been able to see him at times for a week, if not for the fact that at times, they would be too hungry to fall asleep and would wait up until he came back from work, usually with a loaf of bread as was the case the night before. Her mother had a job as a cleaner in a private firm but was downsized during a major reorganization at the firm and had not been able to find another job since then.

As usual, her father had left early that morning leaving instructions with her mother on how to negotiate with the couple who were coming to engage Ekaete's services. He told her mother the salary to ask for and to collect two months' upfront payment.

A few hours later Eno came running with his football clutched under his arm. "Eka, they are here, they are here."

"How do you know they are the people we are expecting?"

"I know because they are heading this way."

Ekaete looked up and saw the couple coming and went inside the room with her other sisters. Her mother cleaned out the bench briskly and dropped the dirty piece of cloth out of sight. Ekaete and her sisters peeped at the couple from behind the worn-out door blinds. Her mother welcomed the well-dressed couple, and they sat down on the bench and talked with her for a while. The man brought out a bundle of money and handed it over to her mother. The four sisters looked at each other in awe. They have never seen such an amount of money apiece before.

"Eka come and greet your new madam and oga."

Ekaete stepped out gingerly from behind the door and curtsied and greeted the couple.

"Ekeate how are you?"

"I'm fine ma."

"I am Mrs. Esther Daniels, and this is my husband Mr. Daniels. You know we are traveling to Lagos with you today, don't You?"

"I know ma."

"Good, go and pick up your bag so we can leave. We are already running late." The Daniels stood up ready to go. Ekeate's mother stood up as well clutching the bundle of money under her arm.

"Yes, ma."

Ekaete went behind the blind and hugged her sisters with tears in her eyes and picked up her bag. Mrs. Daniel turned as she came out with the bag.

"Is that all you are traveling with?"

"Yes, ma."

"Let me see what's inside." She looked into the bag,

"You can leave the dresses for your sisters. I will buy some new ones for you." Ekaete stepped back and gave the bag to Rose and waved to all of them again.

"Bye-bye, mama."

"Bye-bye, Eka. Be a good girl and show Mr. and Mrs. Daniel that you were well brought up."

Ekaete did not reply, instead, she turned and waved again to Eno whose face had puckered up in sadness. He was going to miss his favourite sister. He followed them to the car and stood beside the car, the Daniels sat at the back and asked Eka to sit in front with the driver. She hugged her brother once more and promised to see him soon and he burst into tears. She boarded the car and waved to Eno trying hard to hold back her tears.

The journey to Lagos lasted for about six hours and Eka hardly noticed the cities they passed through. She was too nervous to sleep and sad to take an interest in anything. They arrived at their destination at dusk. They all disembarked and climbed the stairs to the third floor of the four-story building. A young woman and two little children were at the door to welcome them.



"Welcome to our house Ekaete, these are my children, the two older ones are away at school, they will be back in about a month, and this is my niece, I asked her to come and look after the children while I'm away. Come with me I will show you to your room and we will go and make dinner."

The Daniels lived in a four-bedroom apartment, she took Eka to a room with two medium-sized beds and a chest of drawers.

"This is the children's room, you will keep your bag and stuff here, at night you will carry the mattress under the bed and sleep in the living room or you can sleep with it on the floor here, the choice is yours."

"Yes, ma."

Mrs. Daniel went into another room and brought a bag full of clothing.

"These are my daughter's old clothing, she's about your age and height, I guess they will fit. Tomorrow you will choose the ones you like."

"Thank you, ma."

"Now go and wash your hands in the bathroom sink and let's go to the kitchen."

She went the way she was pointed to and washed her hands and walked briskly behind the madam to the kitchen.

"Do you know how to cook?"

"Yes, ma."

"Good, I was told you know how to cook that is the reason I employed you. From tomorrow you will do all the cooking, tonight we will just warm up the rice in the fridge for dinner."

"Yes, ma."

"This is your job description, in the morning you will get up by six o'clock, clean the kitchen and make breakfast for the children and get them ready for school. My husband doesn't eat breakfast except on weekends, and I take my breakfast to work. When we all leave, you will clean the house and prepare lunch."

"Yes, ma."

She pointed to the menu chart on the fridge door, "That is the menu for each day. The weekends can be varied, I will let you know any day we want to eat something else from what is there."

"Yes, ma."

“Now go and set the table for dinner. Do you know how to set the table?”

“No ma.”

“Come, I will show you.”

They both went to the dining table and Eka watched as she set the table. She hoped she would remember. She has hardly had time to catch her breath since they arrived.

## Chapter Four

Ekaete did the last bit of housework for the morning and took some time off to relax on the balcony of the sitting room. She sat on a high stool and stared at passers-by. It has been one month since she came to Lagos and the home of the Daniels. She adapted well to her new home and did her work diligently. The Daniels were impressed and so far, she has not had any problem with either of them. She hoped she would get along with the other two teenagers who would soon come back for the midterm break.

It was mid-morning, and she loved this time of the day best. It was the time she rested. Sometimes she would pick up any piece of write-up and read and at other times she would read old newspapers lying around. Mr. and Mrs. Daniel usually left for work with their two younger children whom they dropped off at school on their way to work, leaving her alone in the house to clean up and get their lunch ready by the time the children came back. Her job in the Daniels' house was not different from what she did at home, only it was better organized and fussy in her new home.

In a bit, she would take a nap and wake up exactly an hour later to take her bath and start preparing lunch. An inner time clock always woke her up within an hour, that was a discovery she has made about herself. She settled down on the old couch on the balcony and dozed off.

"Kpom kpom kpom kpom"

"Knock knock knock knock"

Ekaete jumped up from the couch and ran to the front door, her inner clock was not up. She observed she has not slept for close to ten minutes as she glanced up at the wall clock. She looked through the peephole and saw her madam and two other people. She frantically unbolted the barricade at the door and unlocked the three padlocks. Unlocking the front door was tedious because of the security precautions. On a good day, everybody took the back door and came in through the kitchen. She turned the lock and opened the door.

"Welcome, ma."

"Ekeate what were you doing? Sleeping at this time of the day?"

"Yes, ma. I dozed off on the couch outside."

Mrs. Daniel breathed heavily, eyed her briefly, and kept quiet. Ekeate turned to the new arrivals and greeted them. She bent down to carry their boxes, but the duo beat her to it and carried their boxes inside by themselves. She greeted them again as they came into the house.

"Welcome brother, welcome sister."

"How are you?"

"I'm fine sister."

Jane smiled at the new house help; she was impressed by her honesty. The few they have had before would have lied to her mother's question about sleeping, even with their droopy eyes. Their mother turned to leave.

"I'm going back to the office; my CEO is around, and I must run back. Jane, help Ekaete and get yourselves something to eat."

"Yes mummy, bye mummy."

"Bye dear, see you later."

Jane went into her room and saw that everywhere has been cleaned and the cloth she left behind were properly arranged in her drawer. She touched the top of the drawer and the dressing mirror and felt it has been cleaned as well. She peeped into her brother's room adjacent to hers and saw everything well arranged. David, she was sure had not taken any notice. He was sprawled out on the bed with his eyes closed. In a few minutes now he would barge into the kitchen to ask for food.

Ekaete went into the kitchen to boil water. She did not know if she should prepare breakfast or lunch.

"What is the water for?" Ekaete turned in surprise to see Jane already in the kitchen. She didn't hear her come in.

"I am boiling water to make semolina for lunch."

"I don't want lunch; I want to drink tea. You can make the food for David. He will soon ask for it. We've not eaten since morning."

"Yes, sister."

"Stop calling me sister, call me Jane. My name is Jane."

"Yes sis, yes Jane."

"How old are you?"

"I'm fifteen."

"O yeah, you look way older than that. I'm fifteen too, but nobody would guess we are the same age."

"Why are you not in school?"

"I was in JS3 when I was withdrawn from school because I couldn't pay my fees."

"Mm, JS3 and you speak good English, well I think you should be in school. Anyway, give me a shout when the water boils."

Ekaete liked the way Jane moved her hands and body for emphasis as she spoke. It almost made her laugh, but she smiled at her in admiration. She sensed she would like Jane just as she did the rest. She got the semolina ready and poured the water into a flask and took it to Jane. She met David in the passage.

"Brother, which soup should I warm for you?"

"I am not your brother; my name is David. Give me any available soup." He looked somewhere above Ekaete's head as he answered her question. He had not looked in her direction since he arrived. He acted and sounded insolent, but she chose not to be offended. Ekaete got their breakfast and lunch ready respectively, she knew with the arrival of Jane and David her midmorning rest time was over. She looked forward to the possibly new things that would replace it.

## Chapter Five

"Aisha you will travel home next week. Your father asked me to send you home."

"Why, Aunt Meimuna, in the middle of a school term? We will soon sit for the common entrance examination."

"I don't know. I explained that to him and he insisted you should come."

Aisha frowned, perplexed and angry. It has been three years since she came to Abuja and has not visited home. She did not want to go home. She enjoyed studying and was one of the best pupils in her class. She has been studying hard to pass her common entrance examination.

"Aunty Meimuna I will not go home until I sit for the entrance examination. Tell my father I said so the next time he asks for me." She said firmly.

Meimuna looked up at Aisha with a smile hovering over her lips and remained silent. She loved her niece and her independent spirit. She hoped her daughters will have Aisha's spirit.

At the end of the school term, Aisha travelled home to find out why her father wanted her back home. As she walked the distance between the highway and her father's house, the contrast between Gantu and the city hit her afresh. The ground was hard and crusty, yet the grains and vegetables on the farm looked green and healthy. Everywhere was quiet. The hustle and bustle in the city were completely lost in Gantu. The villagers she passed on the way walked with the same measured unhurried pace as if they were programmed. Nobody was in a hurry to go anywhere. There was no urgent pursuit.

As she got closer to her house, some of her siblings saw her and ran to hug her and compliment her dress. They stared at her in amazement at her new look. She wore a long black skirt and a beautiful red blouse. She looked different from the Aisha they could remember. They were proud of their big sister who came from the city.

"Welcome Aisha, her mother got up to hug her. You are looking all grown up and your eyes seem to have grown bigger," she said with a smile.

"Mother, people's eyes don't grow bigger as they grow."

Aisha stared at everyone and everything. The house still looked the same, though a little dilapidated. The mat she slept on was looking threadbare on the dusty dry floor. Nothing has changed these past three years since she left home which seemed like ten. She wondered if she could ever fit into this way of life again. Aisha's friend Adama came to welcome her as well and they sat chatting till her father came back.

"Aisha my daughter you are back." Her father's delighted greeting interrupted their chatter.

"Yes father, I greet you, father." She also greeted the man who came in with her father. She had known him to be her father's friend as far as she could remember.

"I heard you refused to come home earlier than now."

"Yes father, I sat for the entrance examination to attend secondary school."

"What do you want all that education for? The place of a woman is in her husband's house."

"Father, education is also necessary. A woman can get educated and still occupy her place in her husband's house."

Her father looked at her sharply, this side of Aisha was new to him. She hardly answered back in such a manner before she left for the city.

"Talking about husband, I want to introduce your husband to you, Mallam Shehu. He asked for your hand in marriage, and we have concluded all the marriage rites".

"Mallam Shehu, my husband? How can he be my husband?"

"Yes, you were betrothed to Shehu when you were a child. We have been waiting for you to come back. Your marriage ceremony has been fixed for next week."

Aisha couldn't believe she heard right, she stared at her father shocked. She looked at her mother, willing her to say something, to

come to her rescue, but she sat there staring at the floor without saying a word.

“Father!! Please I want to attend secondary school, please, I would marry when I graduate from secondary school. I thought that was why you allowed me to go to the city.”

“I did not want you to go to the city at all, but your mother and aunty insisted.”

Aisha looked from her mother to her father to Mallam Shehu. She couldn't believe what she just heard. She Aisha, betrothed to Mallam Shehu who was old enough to be her grandfather? Who lived in a hut just like theirs in this village? Aisha saw her dreams crumbling around her like a demolished building. This was not happening to her.

“No father”, she said defiantly, “I will not marry Mallam Shehu or anybody for that matter for now. I will go back to Abuja, attend secondary school, and graduate before I marry.”

“Aisha I can see the city has affected you negatively,” Shehu spoke up for the first time since entering the house. “A woman does not talk back to her father like that.” Aisha ignored him.

“Aisha, I did not ask you if you wanted to marry Shehu. I said you are engaged to be married, and your wedding has been fixed for next week.”

Aisha got up and walked out of the room and went and sat down on the floor close to the entrance of the barn. Adama bade her goodbye and left. Aisha felt dazed by what her father just said, she couldn't believe her world would change within a few hours she got back home. She weighed her options. Should she run away? She couldn't get to the main highway without being caught, besides that, she was not quite sure of the route to take her back to the city. She couldn't go back alone. Aisha knew that girls her age in the village were married and some already had children. Before she went to the city, she had accepted that as a way of life and looked forward to the day of her marriage but her exposure to the city had changed all that. In the city, she saw girls who were educated and had jobs, husbands and children as well. They lived in good houses with their educated husbands. that appealed to her more



than what she had been exposed to in the village. Although some of the girls from her part of the country who lived in the city married early as well, they lived in good houses and had rich husbands.

Mallam Shehu did not fit anywhere into Aisha's dreams. Mallam Shehu her husband-to-be? It sounded surreal and almost funny. Mallam Shehu had two wives and children who were already married. He was illiterate and shabby looking and had no sustainable means of income. Did her Aunt Meimuna know about this marriage plan? Her aunt, who encouraged her to learn and told her to marry a rich man with a big car so that one day she could ride in a car alongside her favourite niece. Aisha's eyes filled with tears and a big tear drops rolled down her cheeks. She felt helpless.

"Aisha, stop crying. Are you crying because you are about to get married? You should be happy at the thought of celebrating your Nikhai, it is every girl's dream."

Aisha did not look up as her mother came and sat beside her and tried to console her. When her mother noticed, she was not listening to her, she stopped talking. She was a little angry with her sister Meimuna. This was all her fault; she was the one that filled Aisha's head with unrealizable dreams. She had allowed herself to dream along with them for a while but stopped after failing to dissuade her husband from marrying Aisha off to Shehu. The betrothal story was a lie. Her husband was marrying Aisha off to pay back a debt he owed Shehu, but she was not about to tell Aisha that. She sat down beside her daughter feeling as helpless as her

## Chapter Six

On the day of her marriage, Aisha sat there untouched by the hustle and bustle going on around her. What would have been a joyous occasion was tempered by her indifference and sadness. The story that she had tried running away a few days earlier was also a topic of hushed discussions amongst the women. It was unheard of in the village of Gantu that a girl of marriageable age would attempt to run away in order not to marry. Most of the women concluded that Aisha needed special prayers from the Imam to bring her back to her senses. Aisha went through the marriage rites in a daze and completely shut her mind to what was going on around her. At the end of it, she went home with Shehu in the company of the older wives.

The pain started somewhere down her thighs and spread all over her body. Aisha woke up aching in body and soul. Shehu lay by her side snoring. On her wedding night, Aisha could not respond to her husband's sexual advances, and in frustration, Shehu raped her, and that happened severally. Aisha lay there wondering how long this would go on. She could not accept Shehu as her husband. This emotional rejection shut off her body from responding to Shehu. She rolled to the end of the mat and got up, trying not to wake him. She wished he would go back to his other wives and leave her alone. The room was still dark though it was already dawn. She could make out the silhouette of the door. She stood up and quietly opened the door and stepped out.

The room she shared with Shehu was at the end of a row of small rooms built in a semi-circle. His two other wives shared a room each with their children. A small hut that stood on its own served as a common kitchen for the three wives. Another mud hut, the size and shape of a large anthill was used to store grains. The bathroom was built a little farther from the compound. There was no toilet. The whole village shared a toilet built by the village head close to his house. Traditionally they went into the bush to answer the call of nature, and

most people still preferred the old ways and only used the public toilet on occasions. Aisha picked up the broom and started sweeping.

"Aisha, what are you doing up this early morning? A newlywed girl should be enjoying her honeymoon."

It was the senior wife, Mariam. She and the other wife had been curious about Aisha's early morning house cleaning, and she could no longer keep quiet. She could not discuss it with their husband either. Aisha looked down embarrassed without saying a word.

"Aisha, you have not answered my question. Are you ignoring me?"

Mariam watched the sad young girl who continued sweeping without uttering a word. This was not the vivacious girl she knew who left for the city a few years back. She didn't know how to help Aisha because she couldn't understand her. She couldn't understand what she needed an education for and why it was more important to her than marriage.

"Since you chose not to answer me at least you can greet me."

"Ina kwana, baaba?"

"Ina kwana, Aisha?"

Meimuna came out from her room to greet the Ogarans as they came back from work, she knew that soon they will start enquiring about Aisha, she had told them earlier that Aisha went home for holidays, and she dreaded telling them she has been married off back home. Just as she expected Mrs. Ogaran threw the question.

"Meimuna, I've not seen Aisha for a while now and I understand that the new school year started a few weeks back."

"Yes ma, she neva come. I go visit home and see why she neva come." She answered a little self-consciously, hoping she sounded truthful.

"As soon as she comes, let me know. I will pay the tuition for her secondary education."

"Yes ma, thank you ma."

"When are you planning to travel?"

"Next week ma"

"Good."

Meimuna felt uneasy and sad, she didn't want to tell her husband's employers right away because she sensed they might be angry since their culture differed from hers. She wanted to go home and find out what happened. For the umpteenth time, she blamed herself for not traveling home with Aisha, though she knew she wouldn't have been able to stop Aisha's father from giving her away in marriage. She had hoped her elder sister would have acted on what she told her three years ago or at least helped Aisha to escape back to the city. Meimuna set out for Gantu three days later brimming with rage at her niece's lost opportunity. As soon as she got home, she went straight to her sister's house.

"How could you allow your husband to marry off Aisha after all I discussed with you?" Meimuna asked her sister sounding as angry as she felt all through her journey back.

"Leave me alone Meimuna. Do you want me to fight tradition? This is all your fault. You are the one who put all those strange ideas into Aisha's head. Now she cannot be happy because of you."

"She is not happy because of me.

So, I'm now guilty because I wanted your daughter to have a good life. You live in the dark and refuse to see the light."

"We are better off in the dark Meimuna. You were once in the dark and happy too."

"Stop talking about happiness, you don't know what it means. If Aisha had finished her education, she would have given you a better life."

"I'm alright the way I live. "

"Talk about 'what you don't know, you don't miss."

"What does that mean."

"You wouldn't know."

"You are unbelievable Meimuna, you talk as if you didn't live in this village six years ago."

"Six years is a long time if only you knew, you should have tried to help Aisha run back to the city."

"What are you talking about? Girls her age are all married, I was married before I was her age."

"It is useless to carry on this conversation, I'm going to see Aisha."

"Good, see if you can talk some sense into her, you are the one that took her to the city. I don't know what people eat in the city that turns their heads and make them crazy."

Meimuna left and headed to Shehu's compound, she hoped she would not see him or his older wives because she was in no mood to exchange pleasantries she didn't feel.

"Aunty Meimuna," Aisha shouted excitedly and hugged her aunt.

"How are you, Aisha?"

She looked away without answering.

"Aisha I'm sorry, I shouldn't have let you come."

"But Aunty, you should have known they were going to marry me off. I think you knew all along."

"I thought your mother would have acted on what I told her the day I came to pick you up from the village. I told her never to let your father give you out in marriage until you had some education, even if I'm not around."

"My mother couldn't have done anything, she is illiterate."

"I'm disappointed in your mother, she just couldn't stand up to your father."

"She didn't even try."

Aisha sat down feeling a little dizzy. Meimuna looked at her with concern.

"Aisha, are you pregnant already?"

Aisha broke down in tears and Meimuna held her close to comfort her. They both sat there for a long time without saying a word. All her dreams for her beautiful niece had come to nothing after all. She had to do something to help her niece but did not know what or how. She could ask her husband to find a job in the city for Shehu, but he was too old to do menial jobs in the city and would not leave the rest of his family.

Aisha stopped sobbing after a while and sat staring at nothing. As Meimuna got up to go, she smiled weakly at her niece and promised to see her again soon. All she got for a reply was the sadness she saw in the eyes of Aisha.

All through her pregnancy, Aisha daydreamed about the city. What she missed most were electricity and television. At least Aunt Meimuna's husband had a television set. Whenever her friend Adama came to visit, she would tell her about her stay in the city and all the wonders of electricity and television, and some of the things she learned at school. It helped her keep the memory of city life alive and helped her remember the important things she learned at school, especially the English language.

## Chapter Seven

Ekaete observed Jane's mannerisms and tried to emulate her. She soaked in every new word, every new move, and even Jane's mode of dressing. She believed Jane was more enlightened and had better exposure than she did and became her willing student. If Jane noticed, she did not show it. Behind Ekaete's desire for polish and poise was the greater desire to be noticed by David who since they arrived studiously ignored her. David walked with the bounce and energy of a budding adult and spoke with the same authority. He kept a handful of friends his age who frequently came to visit him and Eka observed how they listened to whatever he had to say with rapt attention. Occasionally the girl living on the second floor of the building came around to visit David when their parents had gone to work. Eka also observed the way she dressed and talked.

Ekaete's daily routine has changed. Every morning she would wake up much earlier than she used to, brush her teeth, take her bath, and put on a dab of powder before starting her work for the day. At night she would stay up longer than everybody to iron the cloth she would wear the next day and hang them on the chair in the room where she slept. She enjoyed the new feeling of poise and confidence that came with it. Ekaete primed up any time David came around her. She was at his beck and call. She watched every move David's girlfriend made and mimicked the way she walked and talked. She mimicked the way she smiled and her gestures as well. She observed the way she sat with her back straight up, and she practiced doing that whenever she sat down. Every day she added something new to her book of mannerisms. She was in a constant state of elation, and she was happy although her object of interest never looked in her direction. But Jane did, and she watched with amusement as Ekaete tried hard to impress her and her brother by mimicking his girlfriend's every gesture and that of Jane herself. At least it brought Ekaete up to speed on feminine poise and she encouraged her as subtly as she could. She believed Ekaete deserved more out of life than just being a house girl.

"Mummy, why don't you register Eka in a nearby secondary school? She is an intelligent girl and I believe she will do well in school."

Jane stood behind her mummy in front of the dressing mirror in her mother's room, trying to hold her mother's hair in a ponytail. She had a snack for hairdressing and her mummy loved to let her style her hair any time she was home. Her mother looked at her in the mirror.

"She is here as a house girl and I'm paying her a salary, remember?"

"Yes, mum but why don't you stop the salary and pay her school fees with it instead?"

"Her parents need the money for the upkeep of the rest of the family."

"With good education and a good job or business, she would take better care of her family. They should starve now and enjoy later."

"Go and tell that to Mr. and Mrs. Udoh."

"Is that her parent's name? I wish I could do that. How much are you paying her anyway?"

"Why do you ask? You want to help with the payment?"

"No mummy I can't, but I know that whatever you are paying her, you can afford to pay her school fees."

"Well, you should tell your Daddy that. He is the one making the payments and I know he will listen to you."

"I know Mum, but I want to know your take on it. Would you allow Eka to go to school?"

"Would I allow Eka to go to school? Of course, I will allow her to go to school if it doesn't interfere with her services in the house."

"Thanks, Mum, you are the best."

Jane hugged her mummy. That was all she needed to hear before taking her plea to her father.

"You know mummy, most women wouldn't hear of it, that they are paying their house help salary and still send her to school!"

"Most daughters I know, too, wouldn't be pleading with their mummy to allow the house help to get an education. They would rather they are at home attending to their beck and call."

"Like mother like daughter huh."



"You are my daughter alright, I love the way you packed this hair. I would have spent half an hour trying to hold it in place and still won't be able to have it half as smooth as it looks."

"Thanks mummy. You know what mummy? I am going to have a fashion house as well as my job as a lawyer."

Jane said that with her usual theatrics of moving her hands and body in a pose.

"I plan to start the fashion house even before I graduate. In my first and second year, I will work during the long vacation and save money and start the business in my third year."

"As long as it doesn't interfere with your education, I'm all for it."

"I've even written a mini business plan."

"Yarn me, yarn me, my girl! You even know what a business plan is!"

"Yes, mum. They taught us that in Business Studies."

"Wow, I love that school. I've been telling my friends about it. It is the kind of school we need in this country to develop the skills of our children."

Mrs. Daniel got up to leave and Jane walked her to the front door. Her Daddy was already in the car downstairs waiting. Ekaete smiled as she watched them from the kitchen. She wished she could trade places with Jane or better still develop such a close relationship with her mother. After seeing her mother off, Jane joined Ekaete in the kitchen.

"Eka, I want us to have a little chat."

Ekaete turned from the kitchen sink surprised at the sharpness in Jane's voice.

"Yes Jane, I'm listening."

"Would you like to go back to school?"

"Of course..., yes I would like to go back to school." Ekaete corrected herself quickly.

"You are sure you can cope? It is going to be difficult with the housework you know."

"I can cope, Sister Jane. I can, all I must do is wake up earlier than usual and go to bed late."

"And you will still be able to stay awake and alert in school?"

"Yes, you know I've been reading your English textbook and others since you came, and I usually do that when everyone has gone to bed."

"You mean you come into my room and my bag when I've slept?"

"No o, no, you do leave them on the dining table most times after reading."

"Are you telling me I'm careless with my books?"

"Well to my advantage, sometimes, yes."

"I am not careless. I leave them there to continue reading the next day."

"I didn't say you are."

"Promise me you will study hard and work hard when you start school."

"I promise," Ekaete said with a big smile. That was what Jane liked about their house help; she was always cheerful and never seemed to be offended.

"You know, I think your hair can look better than it does."

Ekaete touched her hair. It was cut low and thick, and she always spent some time combing it to make it look presentable. She did not want to barb her hair and her madam has not mentioned it.

"Come let me braid your hair."

"No, Mummy will scold me. I must take permission from her before I do anything to my hair."

"Don't worry as long as I am the one who did the braid, it will get you faster approval than when you ask for permission."

"Alright, let me finish washing and cleaning."

"Be sure to come when I'm still in the mood to make your hair."

"I will be there in a bit." Ekaete mimicked Jane and both laughed. Jane turned to go and Eka danced around in happiness with soap and water dripping from her hands. She couldn't believe this girl. She inwardly thanked God for having Jane in the house. A new hairdo will add to her visibility.

Three weeks later, Jane and David left for school and Ekaete was registered in a secondary school near the Daniels home to resume her studies in JS3. It was difficult attending school and doing all the housework, but she was determined to study and work hard as she

promised Jane. One month later she took on the role of teaching the younger ones as well.

"Eka come and help the children with their homework. I am writing a paper I will present at the office seminar tomorrow."

"Yes, ma."

Ekaete quickly arranged the plates and pots and wiped the sink dry. She swept out the kitchen, put the waste in the waste bin and covered it neatly, and headed towards the dining area. The boy quickly gave her his textbook.

"She will help me first with my homework."

"No, I gave her my book first."

Julia and Jake struggled over who will be first. Their mother studiously ignored them.

"Alright, we will do the homework simultaneously. Julia, give me your Verbal Reasoning textbook and Jake give me your Mathematics textbook."

"No, you will do my Verbal English first."

"Jake, haven't you heard, about 'ladies first'?"

"Who is a lady, this one, this jankara girl? Please do my homework first joo."

"I'm a lady, mummy Jake is looking for my trouble."

"Please don't let him find it. Jacob, listen to Ekaete and do as she says."

Ekaete brought two exercise books and gave one to each of them.

"You will first write the answers in this book, then we will study the homework together and correct it. Whoever is first to finish, will have me correct his or her own first."

"That is okay, I know I will finish first."

"We will see."

Ekaete used the time they were writing to do her assignment.

"I've finished!"

"I've finished!"

She collected the two books, tore out two leaves from the middle, and gave them to do the quantitative reasoning. When they finished, she sat in the middle between them and corrected their homework simultaneously.

## Chapter Eight

Aisha sat on the mat outside her room to get some fresh air and her mother came to visit her. Her mother stood and observed her for a moment.

"Aisha how are you."

"I'm fine, mother."

"I still feel there's more than one baby in your womb, though the village midwife says it's only one. Your stomach looks big for just one baby on a first pregnancy."

Aisha said nothing. All she did with her mother since her marriage was greet her and answer whatever questions she asked her in monosyllables. She shut her off just like she did everybody else. The only person she had long discussions with was her friend Adama.

"Aisha, I think you should go and see the village midwife today."

"Yes, mother."

Aisha's pregnancy was already nine months gone and she has been told what to expect and what to do by her mother and the older wives. First, her water will break, she will feel a trickle of water down her legs, then she will start having contractions, at which she would go to the village midwife who would talk her through the procedure of childbirth. So far nothing had happened, and she was happy to be left alone in her world. As she sat there, she remembered the Estate hospital where Aunty Meimuna gave birth to her second child and the nurses and the doctors who attended to her. She tried to shut that off her memory as she did most times.

Her mother tried some small talk but saw it was going nowhere and left. After a while, Aisha stood up and walked around the inner court of the house as a form of exercise, a few rounds later she went back to sit on her mat. Late in the evening as she helped the senior wife prepare dinner, she felt a trickle of water down her right leg, she bent down to wipe it off with her hands and observed the colour. She wrestled between running off to inform her mother and going to the village midwife, instead, she went into the house and waited. Nothing

else happened, she only felt a slight pain in her lower back. She lay down on her back and tried to get some sleep but could not. She got up, picked up the bag she had parked earlier, and walked to the midwife's house without telling anyone.

"Aishaaaa" the old woman enthused as Aisha stooped to greet her.

"Get up, look at you; you are trying to kneel with your fat belly."

She helped Aisha up and walked her to the back of the house that served as a labour and delivery room. She asked her to lie on the mat on the floor. Aisha did so and the old woman knelt beside her. Baaba, as the old woman was called, was a wiry old woman with several missing front teeth which made her look scary. Behind the appearance, was an amiable old woman who always tried to make her patients relax during childbirth, especially about-to-be mothers like Aisha.

"Have your water broken?"

"Yes, Baaba"

"How long ago?"

"About an hour or two ago."

"That long? what kept you from coming to see me immediately? Didn't your mother tell you that?"

"She did. I was waiting for the labour to start".

"How would you know if you are in labour?"

Aisha noticed a look of concern flash through Baaba's face as she examined her further. She ignored her last question. Baaba observed Aisha briefly and got up. The girl was not having normal contractions. She went outside leaving Aisha wondering what the problem was.

Baaba went into the bush behind her compound and cut the stem of a perennial plant that grew there. Aisha was not having normal labour. Baaba had delivered hundreds of children in the village and knew when there was a problem and what to do. She brought the stem and gave it to Aisha.

"Chew the stem and the leaf and swallow the juice. It will help speed up labour and reduce the pain of delivery."

"Thank you, Baaba."

Aisha took the stem and started chewing, the tangy bitter taste made her wince inwardly, but she kept a straight face and tried not to panic.

“Chew all of it. I will be back after a while.”

Thirty minutes later, the contractions started. Baaba kept checking on Aisha at intervals, the contraction went on the whole night until the next morning. Early in the morning, Baaba told her she is going out and would be back in a short while. When Baaba came back, she had Aisha's mother in tow and two other women who assisted her during a difficult delivery. Aisha knew nothing about that and did not panic. She felt relieved that there were other younger people around. The four women stood and observed her. Baaba knelt beside Aisha and massaged her stomach. The other women went about boiling water and sterilizing an object they put inside the pot. Aisha's mother fidgeted with growing concern. The women hoped and prayed Aisha would deliver normally.

The massaging went on for a while and Aisha told Baaba she could feel the baby coming. She encouraged her to push. She pushed with all her strength, but nothing happened. After a while she could no longer push, the assisting midwife brought out the object that was in the pot and knelt facing Aisha, Aisha felt a sharp pain and screamed, and passed out just as the midwives brought out the tiny baby girl who was gasping for breath.

Baaba applied a mixture of ground herbs on Aisha's incision and with the help of the others carried her to another mat. She would stay in Baaba's house for three days until the wound begins to heal.

Aisha regained consciousness as her mother put a cup to her mouth and urged her to drink the content. She slowly opened her eyes, and the pain made her wince, she closed her eyes again, she slowly drank the bitter mixture in the cup.

“You will be all right Aisha. The medicine will help you sleep.”

Aisha felt too numbed to speak. She willed the drug to help her sleep forever. Her mother sat beside her carrying the baby who would be sustained with water until Aisha's breast milk starts flowing the next day as the herbal mixture will also help in breast milk production.

Aisha sat on the mat in her room breastfeeding her daughter Laraba. It has been three weeks since her delivery and her incision wound were almost completely healed. She sat staring at nothing, her eyes reflecting the turmoil in her heart. She moved over from the position she sat in and saw that the place was wet again. This has been happening since the day she noticed it a week after her delivery, and she could not explain the cause. Her eyes brimmed with tears of confusion and embarrassment. She got up and changed into a fresh wrapper. She tried to conceal the embarrassment as much as she could by washing her clothing regularly, but the mat did not dry as fast. With each passing day, her room became smellier. She wished her aunty Meimuna would come and visit her. She was the only one she could discuss her problem with. She heard footsteps coming towards her room and quickly covered the urine smear on the mat with a cloth.

"How is my daughter doing?" the senior wife asked as she reached toward Aisha to carry the newborn baby. She sniffed up the baby and looked around.

"Aisha, why is your room always smelling of urine? Do you wash the baby's cloth as often as you should? Come to think of it, I always see you washing, then why this smell?"

Aisha ignored her questions and took the mat outside to dry. Drops of urine trailed her steps as she took the mat outside. The first wife observed this and stepped out of the room carrying the baby with her. She went to see Aisha's mother with Aisha's baby tied to her back. Aisha's mother sat on the bare floor in her courtyard picking stones out of the dried maize that she would store in bags and sell later in the year.

"Mama Aisha, how's the day going?"

"It's going well." She replied.

The senior wife took the baby out from her back and sat beside her. Both observed Laraba's umbilical cord to see how much longer it has healed.

"Mama Aisha, have you noticed anything about Aisha of late?"

"Like what?"

"Haven't you noticed that Aisha's room always smells of urine? I saw her taking the mat out and something tells me the urine on it is not Laraba's."

“Are you saying that Aisha now urinates on the mat?”

The senior wife felt a little embarrassed. She didn't know how to say what she suspected without some embarrassment.

“I think something is wrong with Aisha. Why don't you take her to Baaba to check her up and maybe, find a solution?”

“You have not told me what you think is the matter with Aisha.”

The senior wife picked up the baby and left without a word to the question. Mama Aisha had noticed the abnormality at the time her daughter did. She had hoped it would stop in good time but since the senior wife has noticed, it was time to do something about it as she suggested.

Early the next morning Aisha and her mother went to see Baaba. After examining her and asking her a few questions, she gave her some herbs and roots to boil and drink. For the next three months, Aisha drank all the roots and herbs that Baaba kept prescribing without any change in her uncontrolled urination. Nobody now came into Aisha's room except her mother, siblings and her friend. Shehu had also stopped coming to sleep with her. For that she was happy. At least she had something to thank her sickness for.

A few days later, her mother sent for Meimuna to come and see how she could help Aisha, she sensed people in the city would know what to do about her daughter's plight.



## Chapter Nine

"Eka how are you and how was the school year?"

Ekaete turned in surprise to see David leaning on the balcony rail beside her. David smiled at her. She smiled in return, still stunned to reply. It has been a year since she came to live with the Daniels and David had never spoken to her in such a friendly manner before. Jane was in her room talking with her friend on the phone. They were all on vacation. David sat on the long stool on the balcony and faced Ekaete.

"I can't wait to finish school next year and get into the university. Secondary school is beginning to be boring."

"Boring, how do you mean boring?"

"I mean year after year you keep seeing the same old faces, the same old friends, the same old school buildings, and the same old rules. I want to experience something new. See new faces, a new town, and best of all, live my life every day without having to obey rules."

"Now I know what you mean. It's the school rules you don't want to obey anymore, not necessarily the old faces."

"Well, yes I'm tired of rules."

"But we must obey rules all our lives if we want to do the right thing, whether we are in school or out of it. I'm sure there must be rules to obey in the university too."

"Like what?"

"I don't know." Ekaete shrugged her shoulders. "I know there must be rules and regulations in the university."

"There are no rules at the Uni, there you are your own master, you do what you want and go wherever you want."

"I don't know about that."

"Well, now you know, that is why I can't wait for this school year to end."

"It will soon end; you only have one term to go."

"Yes, but it is looking like forever."

Eka shrugged without answering. David stared at her intently and she looked away, a little embarrassed by his sudden interest. David has been

meaning to kiss Ekaete since he came back a few days ago, it was like he was seeing her for the first time. She had blossomed out in the right places and looked quite attractive. He knew she had tried to get his attention in the past, and now he was ready to give her all the attention she wanted but he had to take his time. They talked for a while longer and he went out to visit his friend. Ekaete watched him from the balcony as he walked to the gate. She liked the way he walked, the way he talked, the way he smiled. How nice it will be to become his wife someday. Ekaete caught herself and laughed out loud, how could she be thinking of marriage now? Besides David was way out of her league. She went into the kitchen to start cooking dinner.

Four days later David sought her out again on the balcony as he had been doing and tried to know more about her family. Ekaete was reluctant to pursue that line of conversation, besides, he stood very close to her, and she couldn't think straight. She started to move away, and he encircled her with his right hand and reached out to touch her breast. Ekaete stiffened, but didn't move, David added more pressure to his touch. Ekaete liked the sensation of the touch. Nobody has touched her like that before, she turned and looked at David and he kissed her still rubbing her breast. At the back of her head, she knew that Jane was in the room and would be angry at her but right now she didn't care, a whole new sensation was taking over her senses. David heard Jane closing her door and slowly released her and went into the sitting room before Jane got there. He had left the TV on for a cover-up. Ekaete covered her mouth with her hands willing Jane not to come to the balcony. Jane investigated the sitting room and saw David sitting on the couch, she went into the kitchen and drank water and went back to her room. David started to go back to the balcony, but Jane called Ekaete from her room. He sat down again. Ekaete walked past him to go and see Jane and they exchanged glances without smiling. David was angry at the interruption and started scheming how to get his sister out of the house while the younger ones were sleeping.

"Where were you Eka?"

"I was at the balcony looking out."

"I want you to help me braid my hair."

"You know I can't braid Jane. The braids won't be smooth, and they won't look nice. Ekaete wanted to be left alone to bask in the feeling of what she just had with David.

"Practice makes perfect. You know you can make a lot of money if you learn how to braid. Do you know what it cost to make a million braids in Lagos? Three thousand naira, in Abuja it costs between five thousand and ten thousand depending on where you make it. Think about how much you can earn in a week just braiding peoples' hair."

Ekaete quietly went behind her to start the braids. What Jane was saying went over her head, it wasn't what she wanted to hear right now.

"Are you alright Eka?"

"Me, I'm alright."

"It is not like you to keep quiet after I've given you such priceless information on what to learn to make money and you should be grateful, I'm offering you my hair to learn with."

"Thank you, sister Jane."

"Sister Jane? Where did that come from?"

"I'm just showing my gratitude to my mentor."

"Oh, you are welcome, mentee." They both laughed.

Jane went on to tell her about what she planned to do in the future but she wasn't listening, she was grappling with her thoughts and she has heard Jane's plans twenty times before.

David's girlfriend was still coming around to visit him and she knew they spent a lot of time in the room alone together whenever Jane was not home. What game was David playing? Whatever it was, she was willing to play along with him.

"Eka didn't you hear my question?"

"I heard you, Jane. You asked if I had watched one movie like that."

"Lovely Ladies, have you?"

"No, I haven't, I hardly have time to watch movies."

"Even while on vacation? Am I not living in this house with you?"

But you have time to stand on the balcony."

Ekaete stiffened. What did Jane mean by that? Did she suspect anything?

"It is not enough time to watch a movie."

“Okay, one of these days I will borrow the movie for you to watch when everyone has gone to bed. There is a lot to learn from it.”

“Alright thank you. I think I’m done here.”

Jane looked at her hair in the mirror.

“I told you practice makes perfect; can’t you see your braids are getting better?”

“Well thank you again for letting me practice with your hair.”

“You are welcome.”

Two nights later, Ekaete felt someone on her mattress, she sat up and peered at the alarm clock on the floor beside her, it was two o’clock in the morning. As she turned to look at him, he bent down to kiss her and fumble her breast in one move, soon he was pulling her nightwear. Ekaete made to draw away, she wasn’t sure she was ready for this, David didn’t allow her time to take a decision, he held tighter and urged her on, she was scared and excited at the same time, and she gave in to the new sensation that filled her senses. She gave in to his demands and was lost in the sensation of the moment. Later David held her close to him and she soon fell asleep, by the time she woke up he was gone. She tried to recall what transpired between her and David but heard Mrs. Daniel opening the kitchen door, she scrambled up from the mattress and quickly put on her dress and went into the kitchen.

“Madame Ekaete, are you just waking up? It is 6. 30am.”

“Yes ma, I overslept. I’m sorry ma.”

“It’s all right if it doesn’t become a habit. Is the alarm clock still working?”

“Yes, ma. I don’t know why it didn’t ring this morning.”

Mrs. Daniel looked at her, made to say something but changed her mind. Ekeate knew it must have been David that put the alarm off, maybe it woke him up at the first ring and he didn’t want the noise so he could get away unnoticed or he deliberately put it off before he left.

The activities of the day kept her busy for the rest of the day and David did not come near her in the afternoon. She noticed he went out with his friends at their usual time out on the balcony. But the following night he was back again with the same urgency and Ekaete didn’t find the time to voice her offense. Their night trysts continued for the rest of

the vacation with a few afternoon caresses in between. As always Ekaete was a willing partner. Sometimes she would try to remember the things her mother told her about how a woman got pregnant. She couldn't remember the details but hoped that she wouldn't get pregnant. She felt she was too young to get pregnant anyway.

## Chapter Ten

Meimuna knocked on Mr. Ogaran's door and he opened the door and let her in.

"Please sir, I need your help."

"How can I help you Mrs. Usman?"

Memuna knelt on the floor "Please I want..."

"Stand up, stand up, you don't have to kneel to me to ask for anything."

"Please sir, I want you to help my niece, Aisha."

"Aisha, what is wrong with her?"

"I hear sey she de urinate all the time since she gave birth to her baby."

"Oh, my Goodness! Meimuna, you shouldn't have allowed Aisha to go home at the time she did. You see, she is suffering from VVF because she married early, and her reproductive organs are not strong enough to deliver a baby."

"But Oga, me I marry early too, why I no suffer dis disease?"

"That's a pertinent question. Everybody is not the same, but it is generally safer for girls to wait until they are eighteen or older. It is at the age of twenty that a woman's reproductive organ is fully developed."

"Oga wetin be BBF?"

"It is VVF not BBF. I will write out the address of the VVF centre that is close to your town. Take Aisha to that hospital, when you get there, the doctor will explain to you what VVF is."

He wrote down the address and gave it to Memuna.

"Yes sir, thank you, sir."

"If there are other girls in your village or community who has the same sickness as Aisha, take them along to the hospital as well."

"Yes sir."

The next day Meimuna travelled to Gantu, praying that the hospital will be able to cure her niece of the disease. She first went to her sister's house and told her about the conversation she had with her husband's employer.

"I will take her to a hospital in Goza, her ailment needs special attention."

"Goza, who said there is a hospital there that can treat her ailment?"

"My husband's employer told me; he gave me the address to the hospital."

"I will tell Aisha's father to ask Mallam Shehu to allow you to take her to the hospital."

"Do we need his consent to take his wife to the hospital?"

"Haba Meimuna, you are talking as if you have lived in the city all your life. You know that is what I should do."

"How long do I have to wait?"

"I will tell him today and wait for his response."

"Let's hope Mallam Shehu will not put up any resistance."

"I don't think so. I heard that he does not go into Aisha's room anymore."

"You heard? don't you talk with your daughter?"

"Aisha refuses to tell me anything. She is still angry with me."

"She has every reason to be angry with you."

"You said there is a hospital in Goza, why is it then that the other girls in the village who had same ailment have not been taken there?"

"Why else? They don't know the hospital exists. Who are the other girls? do I know them?"

"I don't know if you do. Habibat, the wife of Usman and Jumai are both Aisha's age mates. Nobody sees them around anymore. They must be in some kind of isolation."

"I will go and see them and maybe take them along to the hospital."

"You will get Shehu's consent first, it is only when they know Aisha is going there that they will consider going with you."

"That's alright, I will come back tomorrow."

"May Allah keep us."

"Amin."

Meimuna went to visit Aisha. Laraba was sleeping on the mat beside Aisha. She didn't hear her Aunty come in. Meimuna stood for a while observing them. She tapped Aisha gently and she woke up.

"Aunty Meimuna, is that you or am I dreaming?"

"No Aisha, you are not. I came to see you."

Aisha sat up on the mat and Meimuna sat beside her. She lowered her eyes in embarrassment as Meimuna glanced at the wet patch on the mat.

"Aisha, I heard about your ailment and I told Mister Ogaran."

"You told him?"

"Yes, and he asked me to take you to a hospital in Goza where you can be treated."

"Thank you, aunty. I will go with you, when can we leave?"

"Your father will talk to Mallam later today, as soon as he gives you permission we will leave."

"Alright, I hope Mallam will allow me to go with you."

"I'm sure he will."

"How far is the hospital from here?"

"It's about two hours."

"If they admit me to the hospital, will you stay with me?"

"Of course, I will if it is for few days but if takes longer, I will go back and ask my husband if I can stay longer. I heard there are other girls in this village with this same problem. I will go and ask their husbands if I can take them along."

"Do you have money to pay the fare to Goza for all of us?"

"Mister Ogaran gave me some money; it will cover the expenses. He is the one that asked me to take any other girl who has the same ailment as yours."

"Well, all will depend on Mallam consenting to your request."

"Yes, I will leave now. I want to get to my husband's village before it gets dark, I will be back tomorrow, see you then."

Aisha walked her aunt to the entrance of the compound and went back to her room. She didn't want to be seen by anyone.

"Bye Aunty"

"Bye Aisha."



## Chapter Eleven

“Eka what are you eating these days? You are adding a lot of weight. Your Madam must be looking after you well.”

Ekaete smiled at her teacher without answering. She has noticed the weight gain herself. Her school uniform was slightly tighter than before. Her class teacher stared at her as she walked out of the class. She didn't want to dwell on the thought that crossed her mind but decided to observe Ekaete closely.

“I would like to come and visit your Madame, Eka. Does she stay home on Saturdays?”

“Yes, ma. She stays at home on Saturdays if she doesn't have any ceremony to attend.”

“Alright then, tell her I will come and see her next tomorrow.”

Ekaete felt uneasy. Why did her class teacher want to see her employer? They had just finished their exams for the term and were waiting for the teachers to finish marking their papers and grading their performances. She had noticed the woman observing her severally and thought nothing of it. She looked at herself, she wasn't any fatter than she was two months before. The weight gain has stopped just as it had started. She will wait and see why the teacher wants to visit.

On Saturday evening the teacher came just as she promised, Eka hovered around to listen and know why she was there but after a while, her madam sent her out on an errand.

“Eka come and take this money and buy some vegetables from the market, we'll need it to make dinner tonight.”

“Yes, ma.”

“Be sure to buy fresh vegetables.”

“Yes, ma.”

Mrs. Daniel was seated in the sitting room with Ekaete's teacher, and she sent Ekaete out at the prompting of the teacher. Ekaete herself knew that there was something behind it all. The teacher turned to Mrs. Daniel.

“Madam I came to see you because of what I have observed about your house help.”

The teacher hesitated.

“Yes, what is it, is she misbehaving in school or what?”

“No, as a matter of fact, she is a good girl, that is why I’m surprised. I think Ekaete is pregnant.”

“Preg what?”

“I think you should take her to a doctor for confirmation before we reopen for the next term.”

Mrs. Daniel was too stunned to say anything else. Her mind was racing, what is this woman talking about? She didn’t know whether to believe the teacher or walk her out of her house. She silently prayed her husband was not responsible though she has not observed anything suspicious between both.

“I will leave now madam.”

“Alright, madam, I will find out the truth. Have a nice day.”

“Do have a good weekend yourself, madam.”

Good weekend! It was going to be one of her worst. She saw the teacher off and sat back on the couch. How will she handle this information? Should she tell her husband? Should she confront Ekaete? She decided against both, she will have to know the truth first. She will not do anything until her husband travels out of town the following week. If what the teacher said turned out to be true, she would send Ekaete away before her husband returned.

Ekaete came back apprehensive, but her employer did not say anything, but from the look on her face she knew that all was not well. She went about her work till one week later when her madam told her to dress up, they were going to see a doctor. She wondered what they were going to see a doctor for.

They made the trip to the doctor’s clinic in silence. When it was their turn to see the doctor, her madam asked her to come in with her. From the exchange between the two, she knew her madam must have called the doctor before their visit. The doctor told her to lie down, he examined her and asked her to get up and sit down.

“When was the last time you saw your period young lady.”

Ekaete thought for a while. Why this question? Her period has not been regular, so she generally didn't bother with its regularity.

"You can't remember?"

"I think it was two months ago."

"You think? Are you sure?"

"Yes."

"I don't think so because you are three months pregnant."

"What Doctor, are you sure?"

"Yes madam, from my examination she is in her first trimester."

Ekaete looked from the man to her madam and back again to the doctor. What was he talking about? She, pregnant? She wasn't feeling anything. She had seen her mother pregnant and knew that she was sick most of the time and vomited frequently.

"I will still carry out a pregnancy test to be sure and to convince you."

They vaguely heard him. Mrs. Daniel was furious. She felt betrayed and fooled by Ekaete's seeming innocence. She had known her to be honest. How could she have fooled her so? Part of her anger was also fuelled by the anxiety she felt that it must be somebody in her household. She could hardly contain her anger by the time they got home.

"Madam Ekaete, sit down there and tell me who is responsible for your pregnancy."

Ekaete stood there without saying anything. She wished David was around so she could know how he would have felt about this news. She looked down in silence. Mrs. Daniel got up and gave her a slap on her right cheek followed by another on the left. She had never seen her madam so angry. Ekaete started crying which elicited more beatings from her madam. After a while, she couldn't take it anymore.

"It's David."

"What did you just say?"

"It's David. He was sleeping with me most nights during the last holiday."

"It's a lie, you are lying daughter of the devil."

"Mummy it's true. I'm not lying."

“Don’t mummy me, you wicked girl. You were pretending to be innocent. I didn’t know you are an agent of darkness. Even if it is true, you must have seduced him. Do you think you will destroy my son’s life? You will not succeed. Go and pack your cloth you are leaving this house tomorrow.”

“Mummy please, forgive me.”

“Forgive you and do what? Do you want to give birth to a bastard in my house? That will not happen. Get up and get out of my presence.”

The next day Mrs. Daniel took Ekaete to her parents and left without any explanation. She asked Ekeate to tell her parents why she was home and left.

## Chapter Twelve

Meimuna and Aisha went to see Shehu who had requested to see them after he spoke with Aisha's father.

"I want to know how long Aisha will be gone."

"I don't know Mallam, we will find out after seeing the doctor."

"Why I'm asking is, if she will stay long, she should leave Laraba with my first wife. She can take care of the baby while she is gone."

"Laraba is still breastfeeding, she is too young to be weaned now and to stay apart from her mother. We will find out how long Aisha will stay when we get there."

"Okay, Aisha can go with you."

"Mallam, why don't you come with us to the hospital?"

"How can you ask me that Meimuna? You know I won't do that."

"It's settled then; we will leave as soon as Aisha gets her stuff together."

She turned to Aisha.

"Pack your cloth and that of Laraba, I will go and see if the other girls your mother mentioned will go with us."

"Do you know what I think their answer will be?"

"No, what do you think?"

"I think they will ask you to take me there first, when and if I get cured, then they will agree to go."

"Very well, I'll still go and find out if your hunch is correct."

True to the prediction, that was the response she got from the families of the girls. Meimuna felt sorry for the girls, she could see they were eager to go, but they couldn't make the decisions themselves. She promised to see them again sometime in the future.

On the journey to Goza, Aisha sat beside Meimuna on the last seat at the back of the bus. She rolled two of her wrappers together and put them on top of the seat and sat on it. Seating at the back meant they will be the last to disembark so that nobody would notice her condition. While on the bus Aisha decided to stay in the hospital as long as it took to get cured. She did not want to go through this embarrassment any longer.

At the VVF Center, Aisha was surprised to see that most of the girls in and out of the doctor's office, were about her age.

"Aunty, have you noticed how some of these girls walk, they are walking awkwardly."

"Yes, I've seen that Aisha, don't worry, we will find out why eventually. Come let's go, the nurse is beckoning to us to go see the Doctor."

"Ina kwana Aisha"

"Ina kwana Dector"

"What's your problem?"

Aisha narrated her case to the doctor.

"How long were you in labour."

"I don't know doctor, there was no clock in Baaba's backyard."

"Okay lie down on that bed and let me examine you."

Aisha looked from the doctor to her Aunty and back again.

"Meimuna please take the baby to the waiting area while I see Aisha."

"No. I want my aunty here."

"Don't be scared Aisha, I'm not going to harm you."

Aisha did as she was told. After the examination and further questioning the doctor asked Meimuna to come back in.

"Aisha has what is called VVF, it is an obstetrics complication. We don't cure VVF here, but we take care of the patients until they are transferred to a hospital where they can get corrective surgery."

Meimuna stared blankly at the doctor.

"What I'm saying is that we don't cure the disease, but we take care of the patient until we can arrange for the hospital where she can be cured, so we will admit Aisha."

"How long will she stay here and when will she be transferred to the place?"

"The transfer will be determined by the government and not us. Don't worry she will be fine. As you can see there are other girls her age here."

"Can't she go straight to the hospital?"

"No, she will be on admission here until she can be transferred to the hospital."

"Where is the hospital that she will be transferred to."

"I don't know yet, there are three federal hospitals that perform the surgery, she will be admitted into one of those as soon as it is possible."

"Okay decter, I'm asking the questions because I have to explain it to her husband and her parents."

"It's alright, I know."

"I will ask the nurse to get a bed ready for her and her baby."

"Yes, decter, thank you."

## Chapter Thirteen

"Esther, you have not told me why you sent Ekaete home without waiting for me to come back."

"I told you she is a bad girl. She was deceiving everybody."

"Deceiving everyone about what? She has lived here for a whole year without complaint?"

Mr. Daniel waited for an answer as his wife dillydallied.

"Yes, Esther I'm listening."

She looked at her husband. He sounded angry but was trying not to show it. She quickly thought about how she could defend her actions without mentioning her son.

"Emma, Ekaete is pregnant."

"Whaat? Whom did she say impregnated her?"

"She wouldn't say, that was why I took her home. I didn't want her to say who is responsible anyway so that I won't have to find out if it's one of the men in my house."

"Are you insinuating anything, Esther?"

"No Emma, I'm only kidding," She laughed briefly to cover her lie. "It could have been anyone from here to her school."

"You should have waited for me to come back."

"What would you have done?"

"She would have told me the truth."

She said nothing and her husband suspected there was more to what she was saying but let the issue alone for the moment.

As soon as Ekaete's mother got over the shock of the abrupt return of her daughter. She called her into the room and asked her why she was brought home in such a manner. She told her what happened, dry-eyed. While in the car on their way back she made up her mind not to cry anymore. She had cried the whole night before their return and made up her mind crying would not change anything. She wasn't craving her mother's sympathy either. If they had not sent her out to work in another man's house, this would not have happened, or would it? She didn't want her thoughts to go that far.



Her mother took the news with equanimity. Eka was surprised at her mother's calmness. Her mother sat down facing her with her hands clasped together above her thighs and stared at the floor for a long time.

"Have you eaten?"

"No, and I'm not hungry."

"Didn't your madam buy you food from Lagos?"

"She did, but I didn't eat it. I wasn't feeling hungry."

"You have to eat because of your unborn baby."

She felt a little angry. She was not feeling pregnant, it sounded strange and annoying to hear anybody talk about an unborn baby. She couldn't contemplate being a mother.

"What do you want to eat?"

She started to say she wasn't hungry but changed her mind.

"I will eat any food that is available."

Her mother got up to go and get her something to eat. For the first time, Ekaete took notice of the little changes that had taken place in the house. The room looked neater than usual. The six-inch spring bed she shared with her siblings has been replaced with a large bed made with wood, her mother asked her what she wanted to eat, which meant there was food in the house, probably a variety. She came out of the room and looked around the front of the house. Several shanty shops had sprung up in the street and a house now occupied the undeveloped plot opposite their house where her brother and other children used to play soccer. At the thought of her brother, she realized they should have been back from school. She went to the kitchen to take the food her mother was preparing.

"Where are Eno and the rest?"

"They are not back from school."

"It's almost four thirty and they are not back?"

"They stay behind for school lessons after the close of school."

"That means they have changed schools because I know the public school, they were in didn't organize such lessons."

"Yes, they are in the school owned by the church where we worship, they have a primary school."

"I see."

A lot of things have changed in her home. The money she earned at the Daniels must have played a major role in the change, her mother now has a provision store close to their house. And now this, she blanked her mind from any worrisome thought.

As her mother watch her eat, she tried to decide on what to do. She battled with the decision to either take Eka to her Pastor's wife or to send her home to live with her grandmother until she delivers her baby. But right now, the most pressing issue was where her daughter could stay until she explains the situation to her husband. He would be furious, and she didn't want to put Eka in harm's way.

What Ekaete's mother never told her was that she got pregnant as a teenager herself and Ekaete was the product of that pregnancy. Ekaete's father was an apprentice mechanic at a nearby village at the time and her parents had forced them to get married. Was it her fault that her daughter was pregnant now or was it just a twist of fate? She tried to teach Eka some lessons in sex education but knew even then that she never paid attention. It was not a time for reminiscence. She must act and quickly.

"Eka you will have to go and stay with Mama in the village until you have your baby. Your ...."

"I will not go to the village. I am not pregnant."

"But you said the doctor examined you and said you are pregnant."

"I am not feeling any baby in my tummy. Babies move in the womb, don't they?"

"Maybe it has not started moving. Eka you are in denial but with time you will accept the fact."

"I don't want to have a baby."

"What do you want to do? Have an abortion? I will not be a party to an abortion."

Eka said nothing. Having an abortion has not even crossed her mind.

"Right now, I will take you to my friend's house to stay for a few days. I don't want your siblings to know you are back yet, and I will have to tell your father the situation before I decide on what to do next."

Anne Udoh spent the rest of the day rehearsing in her mind how she would break the news of her daughter's pregnancy to her husband.

When they got to her friend's house, she was not yet back from work, they sat on a bench beside her house and waited for her to return. When she came back, Anne explained the situation to her and told her she will come back the next day.

In the afternoon of the next day, Eka's mother came to see her. "Eka you will go to the village and stay with your grandma until the baby is born. That is what I and your father agreed on last night." Ekaete started to say something but her mother continued without giving her the opportunity.

"It is the best for everybody. I don't want your siblings to know that you are pregnant, and I don't want our neighbours to know either. In the village, you will be spared from the snickering from our neighbours and your father's insults. You know how he is when he is angry."

"I don't want to go to the village please, let me stay with my family. Papa does not come home until late at night, by the time he comes back, I will be fast asleep or pretend to be".

"Your father comes home by six o'clock now. Since I started the provision store, he comes home to help me out. Before you left, he was deliberately staying away from home until he was certain you children had slept."

"I wouldn't mind about the neighbours, they can snicker all they want."

"What about your siblings? You wouldn't be a good role model being pregnant at sixteen."

"But mummy they will find out one way or the other. They will see me with the baby or am I going to live in the village permanently with Grandma?"

"They will not find out. If they do see you with a baby, it will be with your husband by your side."

"What do you mean mummy, are you planning to marry me off in the village as well? If you are, forget about it because it's not happening. I will finish my secondary education and get a degree in business administration."

Her mother was surprised at the firmness of Ekaete's statement. Eka herself was surprised at her outburst. How she would accomplish that

she didn't know. At the back of her head, she still hopes and believe that David will come back for her and her baby.

Mother and daughter sat for a while without speaking. Anne had no intention of giving her daughter away in marriage as her parents did in her case. She was only trying to handle the situation as best as she could while trying to protect everybody from psychological damage.

"Mrs. Daniel will come back for me," Ekaete broke the silence. "Jane will convince her mother to take me back when she finds out the truth."

"Did she know you were sleeping with her brother?"

"No, what kind of question is that? Mrs. Daniel will confront David and he will tell her the truth and Jane would insist that her mother brings me back."

"You think so?"

"Yes, I know so."

Anne Udoh let the matter lie. She knew that the boy would not own up to anything but if that hope would help her daughter handle her present challenge, she wasn't going to take it away from her.

"I will come around six o'clock in the morning, do try and wake up early, we need to be at the bus terminal early enough to get a comfortable seat on the bus."

Ekaete didn't remember agreeing to her mother's proposal. She wanted to protest further but kept quiet. Maybe her mother was right. She needed to stay away from the people she knew, only she didn't want to go to the village, and she longed to see her siblings. She would have preferred to stay in the comfort of her family.

That night Ekaete couldn't sleep. She turned and tussled and tried to sleep but sleep eluded her. She had too much on her mind. She didn't want to go to the village. Early the next morning she woke up before her mother's friend did, picked up her bag, and quietly sneaked out of the house. When her mother came to take her to the bus terminal, they realized she had run away.

"Honestly Anne, I didn't hear her leave. It must have been this morning that she left because when I woke up in the night, she was here sleeping."

“I just hope she doesn’t get into any harm. Maybe I should have let her stay when she said she didn’t want to go to the village.”

“Don’t blame yourself Anne, you are trying to do what is best for your daughter, I’m sure she will be fine. We all need to be positive. Let us go to the bus terminal and see if she went there, she might be trying to go back to Lagos.”

“I don’t think so but let’s go anyway. I think we should walk to the bus terminal and see if we can see her anywhere along the road.”

“Yes, let’s go.”

“Ah, I forgot you are going to work, I can go alone, you can stay back and get ready for work.”

“No Anne, I can go late to work, it doesn’t matter.”

## Chapter Fourteen

Ekaete walked three miles to the church where her parents worshiped. She didn't quite know the direction to the church. She had an idea of the location. Her mother's friend was asleep when she sneaked out of the house. Though her mother wanted to hide her pregnancy from everyone, including the Pastor and his wife, Ekaete knew they were her only hope of staying near her parents and siblings. When she got to the church, she saw that the Pastor and his family lived in a house nearby. She walked up to the door and knocked, a young girl opened the door and stood looking at her.

"Good morning, I came to see the Pastor."

"This early morning? Are you a member of the church?"

"No, my parents are members of the church, please would you tell the Pastor's wife that someone is here to see her?"

"May I know your name?"

"My name is Ekaete Udoh, the daughter of Mr. and Mrs. Udoh."

"Wait here, I will be back."

After what seemed like ages, the Pastor's wife came to the door. "Hello good morning, come on in and sit down."

"Thank you, ma."

They both walked to the sitting room and sat facing each other.

"My daughter told me you are Anne's daughter; I've not seen you before."

"Yes, I am her first daughter, I came back from Lagos two days ago."

"Is everything alright with your parents?"

"Yes ma, they are fine, though I have not seen my father and siblings."

"You haven't? why?"

"That is why I'm here ma. I want you to help me."

Ekaete looked down at her hands and twisted her fingers, she laced and unlaced her fingers not knowing how to start stating her case. The Pastor's wife waited patiently.

"Ma, my mother wants to send me to the village, and I don't want to go to the village."

"Why does she want to send you to the village?"

"She doesn't want my father to see me."

"I don't understand, you came back from Lagos two days ago and your mother doesn't want your father to see you. What were you doing in Lagos?"

"I was living with a family as their housemaid."

"And you ran away or what?"

"Yes, no, the woman sent me away because I, I, I'm pregnant".

"And your mother doesn't want your father to know about it?"

"She has told my father and they both agreed I should go to the village so that I won't be a bad role model for my younger sisters, I won't also be taunted by the neighbours."

"So how can we help you?"

"I want to live with you ma, I don't want to live in the village."

"Let me tell Pastor you are here. I will be back."

Eka was surprised the woman did not show any sign of shock or surprise. The Pastor and his wife came back to the sitting room a little while later, and after questioning her further he sent for her parents.

Anne was so happy that her daughter was safe that she was ready to agree to whatever the Pastor had to say. Her parents came in the afternoon, and they all agreed that Eka will go and stay with a missionary couple until her baby is born. The next day the Pastor and his wife called the missionaries to let them know that Ekaete would be coming to stay with them, and they agreed. She would stay with the Pastor and his wife for three days and travel to Bauchi to live with the missionaries.

Jane came back from school at the end of the term tingling with new stories to tell Ekaete. She walked into the sitting room expecting to see her rushing to carry their bags.

"Mummy where is Eka?"

"She is not here."

"Where did she go; didn't she know we are coming back today?"

"Why don't you take your bags inside and find something for both of you to eat? I'm running back to the office now. I only took permission for two hours."

Jane and David looked at their mother in surprise. She did not answer Jane's question and seemed in too much of a hurry to leave. They both took their bags to their rooms and Jane went to the children's room to see if she was there, but she wasn't. She went into the kitchen to drink water and saw that the kitchen was not as neat and organized as it used to be. The used cups and utensils from breakfast were still in the kitchen sink and the floor was not swept from the night before. She drank water and went to her room to rest hoping Ekeate went to the market and would soon return.

David didn't know what to make out of the whole situation. He was hungry, that was his main concern for now. He didn't know if Jane would oblige him to prepare lunch. He knocked on Jane's door and put his head behind the door. "Where could Eka have gone to? I'm hungry and I want to eat, Janie would you help get me lunch?"

Jane wanted to refuse but reluctantly stood from her bed and headed to the kitchen. She was hungry as well. She prepared lunch for both and made no move to wash up the contents of the sink. After eating, she dumped the plates into the sink and went to lie down. A few minutes later, her younger siblings came back from school. After the hugging and pecks, she asked them the question uppermost in her mind.

"Jake where did Ekaete go to?" Jake glanced at Julia, both said nothing.

"Why don't you want to tell me where she went to Jake?"

"Eka has gone back to her parents." Jake blurted out.

"She has gone back to her parents, what happened?"

"We don't know, we came back from school one day and didn't see her, Mummy told us she took Eka back to her parents."

"And you didn't ask her why."

"I did but she didn't say anything," Julia answered before her brother could reply. Jane was mystified by the curious silence surrounding Ekaete's departure. She let the matter go and awaited her mother's return. She went into the kitchen once more to prepare food for her siblings.

David listened to the exchange between Jane and the children with growing annoyance. What could have happened? He didn't want to



return to the old scenario of having to beg Jane to make his food and he was looking forward to his affair with Eka. And why was their mother not telling the reason for her leaving? Could it be that she is pregnant? The thought jolted him. He went into his room and sat down. He hadn't used any form of protection as he did with the girl next door, and it was deliberate. He felt condoms were restrictive and limiting. Eka provided the ultimate pleasure he craved without the condom. Could she have told his mother anything? He thought of what he would say if that was the case. Jane waited for her mummy to come back. Their mother came back several hours later. After settling down for a few minutes, Jane asked the question.

"Mummy, Julia told me you took Eka back to her parents, what happened?"

"I don't want her to be a bad influence on my young children."

"Bad influence? What do you mean by bad influence? As far as I know, I have learned one or two things from her on good housekeeping, so what bad influence are you talking about Mum?"

Esther hesitated, she had hoped her remark would give her a good opening for what she had to say, but it wasn't working. She thought for a moment about how to break the news in a more shocking manner.

"Ekaete is pregnant."

Jane stared at her mother for a moment as if her mummy had gone a little crazy. Esther went on to elaborate.

"I didn't have a clue that she was pregnant until her teacher came to the house to see me and asked me to take her to the hospital for confirmation."

"And it was confirmed that she was pregnant?"

"Of course, yes, the doctor confirmed that she was ten weeks pregnant."

"I can't believe this."

"Believe it my dear because it is true."

Jane let the information sink in, and her mind started racing. Ten weeks pregnant, that meant she must have gotten pregnant while they were home for the holidays. She never saw Ekaete leave the house alone or go out on her own. She had always accompanied her to the market and that was the only time she could have gone to see a boyfriend outside the

house, or maybe the boyfriend was inside the house. Esther got a little uneasy with Jane's silence.

"Mummy, did you ask her who is responsible for her pregnancy?"

"Do you honestly think she would tell me the truth about that? If she was sleeping with a man and could manage to act like a little innocent girl at the same time, then nothing she had to say mattered."

"Mum, you have not answered my question."

"What was your question? Who got her pregnant? I'm not interested in who got her pregnant. I took her home to protect my children."

"Who amongst your children are you protecting?"

"What kind of question is that? Jane!! Julia is still young and can be influenced by a bad girl and you too, she's about your age."

"Really mum? Did she mention anybody like David?"

Esther looked up angrily at her daughter with a faked shock on her face.

"David? Did you see her in any compromising position with David?"

"Do the mathematics Mum, if she was ten weeks pregnant when you took her home, that means she got pregnant while we were home on our previous vacation."

"That does not mean..."

"Let me finish Mum. While we were home, I always went to the market with Eka, and I never saw her leave this house at any other time long enough to visit a boyfriend. If she is pregnant, then somebody in this house is responsible. Now mummy who did she say is the father of her baby?"

Esther was shocked at her daughter's reaction and insistence on her answering her question.

"Do you know that you are inadvertently accusing your brother or your father to be the father of Ekaete's baby?"

"If any of them is the father then somebody should own up to it."

"And then what?"

"I can't believe you are asking that question mummy. A young girl's future has been compromised and probably ruined. Somebody should at least take responsibility. It could be your daughter any day." Jane said angrily, her voice rising.

Esther had no answer to that and said nothing and Jane left the room in annoyance banging the door behind her. She would have to ask her son a few questions, but not today, she would wait for a few days. Jane had other plans.

After dinner that day, the whole family sat in the sitting room and talked about school and what they would do to keep themselves busy. David had taken his final exam at school and had a long time to wait before his JAMB result would be out. Jane saw the younger ones to bed and came back to the sitting room. She listened for a while as her daddy enquired from David if he would want to take a vacation job to which he readily agreed.

“Daddy, Mummy told me that she took Eka home because she was pregnant.”

The room went quiet. Her father spoke up.

“Yes, my dear, I wasn’t even at home then. I went on official duty to Kogi State, and by the time I came back she was gone.”

Another short silence followed. Esther Daniel was fuming with rage at her daughter’s audacity to take the matter out of her hands. She knew where the question was going and tried to think up something to change the subject. Her daughter continued without giving her the time to do that.

“Mummy told me she did not ask her who is responsible for her pregnancy. I think that is curious because whoever is responsible should be made to pay for his irresponsibility or at least own up.”

David froze where he sat but managed to keep a straight face. Their mother tried to contain her anger.

“What do you suggest Jane?”

“I think we should get to the root of this matter. Somebody should visit Eka or better still, she could be brought back to tell us who the father of her baby is.”

“What errant nonsense. That girl is not coming back to my house. She could come and point to anybody. Stories of housemaids ruining families abound. She could...”

"Stories of housemaids being raped or seduced also abound mummy." Jane cut off her mom mid-sentence. Another silence followed. Her Daddy intervened.

"Jane, I know that Ekaete is your friend, but I don't think that is enough reason to start an accusation."

"I am not accusing anybody Daddy. I believe everybody is innocent until proven guilty, I also believe in justice and fairness. I don't think Eka has been treated with fairness. At least she deserves to be heard. It could be proven who the father is after she gives birth."

"How?"

"By conducting a paternity test!"

"Do you know how much it costs to do that?"

"Whatever it costs Dad, that would be the cost of justice."

Esther rose to leave. "I'm not listening to any more of this conversation."

"Sit down Esther, Jane has a point here. If anybody should be offended it should be the two men in this house and we are not, or are we, David?"

"No Daddy, I'm not offended."

Jane was surprised at the calmness in David's voice. She had hoped to hear a trace of anxiety in his voice. She had to make her case tactfully in order not to make permanent enemies in the house.

"Alright then, David do you know anything about Ekaete's pregnancy?"

"No Dad, I don't."

"Honestly?"

"Honestly Dad I don't."

"Well, I on my part can swear that I'm not the father of her baby so that brings us back to Jane's suggestion. What do we do to ensure that Ekaete gets fair treatment? We should get to the root of who impregnated her. Esther, what do you have to say?"

"What I have to say is that Ekaete is not coming back to this house. I have my young children to protect. I will not have an answer when they start asking why Ekaete's stomach is big and I am going to bed."

With that, Esther Daniel went to bed and a long silence stayed behind.

## Chapter Fifteen

The afternoon shift nurse asked Aisha to come with her to the ward assigned to her and her baby with Meimuna in tow. The wards were four separate buildings built like a square in a chess board, one walkway connected each ward to the other. A large empty area inside the square served as a recreational space for the patients. Several tiny cribs and young mothers sat on plastic chairs outside. Aisha was shown to her bed in ward B. There were several beds and cribs in the room and empty spaces in between. Aisha noticed there were fewer beds in the ward than she remembered from her visit to the estate hospital in Abuja.

"This is your bed Aisha, and the crib is for your baby. We don't usually admit mothers with their babies except in some instances. As a rule, we don't admit mothers who are still breastfeeding except in some serious cases."

"Does that mean Aisha's case is serious? Meimuna asked anxiously.

"I didn't say that every case here is serious." The nurse turned to Aisha.

"Everything you need is in the bedside drawer; you can put your stuff in there too. I will be back later for your medication. Do you have any questions?"

"Can my aunty sleep on the same bed with me?"

"Oh no, visitors are not allowed to sleep in the wards. Is your aunty not going back today?"

"No, I want her to stay with me for a few days before she goes back."

"I don't think that will be possible Aisha, I will ask my supervisor if she can spend the night in the nurses' station till tomorrow."

"I will appreciate that," Meimuna spoke up. I can't leave today because it won't be possible for me to get transportation back to Gantu by this time of day."

"I know, we've had mothers and aunties sleeping over all the time so I know my supervisor will oblige but it's not going to be more than a night."

"Okay, thanks."

"Why are the girls I saw walking awkwardly and slowly?"

"It's because they have urine bags that collect the urine, so it doesn't drip or leak while they are standing or sitting."

"Does that mean I will be walking like that too? What is a urine bag? I don't want to walk like that."

"Okay, Aisha, the doctor is still evaluating your case. By the time I come back, I will explain everything to you and see if you do have any options."

"Thank you, nurse."

"You are welcome, I will be back."

"Aunty Meimuna, this ward is virtually empty. Why are there few beds here? The other wards we passed are full like the estate hospital in Abuja."

"Yes, I can see that, the nurse said this ward is for mothers who are here with their children."

"That means all those girls outside with their babies are from this ward."

"That's what it means, that's why there's nobody in here I guess."

"You know Aunty, I'm happy to be here, away from Gantu, away from that old man, and away from sleeping on the bare floor."

Meimuna said nothing, she was still thinking about the urine bags the nurse mentioned, she hoped they would recommend something else for her niece. She tried not to show her discomfort.

"Sit down and carry the baby so I can put your stuff in the drawer."

Aisha made to sit on the bed but checked herself. She had forgotten her ailment altogether for a while. She ran her hands on her wrapper and felt some wetness. She lifted the outer covering on the bed and sat on the blanket beneath. Meimuna laid out the clean clothing in the first drawer and put her toothbrush, toothpaste, bath soap, and Vaseline cream in the second. She wrapped the soiled clothing in a nylon bag and put it beside the bed. They sat down and waited for the nurse to return.

Ekaete sat on the bus with her mother on their way to the bus park, from the discussions with the Pastors and the missionaries, she would need to board a vehicle to Bauchi state capital, the missionaries will pick her up from the park and take her to their mission post which was an hour

distance from the state capital. The Pastor wrote down the direction on a piece of paper and she put it in her handbag.

"Eka when you get there try to be as helpful as you can to Grace, she is a good Christian and she will take good care of you, I'm sure."

"Do you know her?"

"Yes, I saw her once when they attended a program in our church."

"You never mentioned that you knew her and nobody ever mentioned her name or that of her husband. All I've heard everyone say is 'the missionaries. Come to think of it, I don't even know their names, if anything happens to me on the way, I wouldn't even know the name of the people I'm going to meet."

"I think Pastor wrote their name on the piece of paper he gave you."

"No, he didn't."

"I think he did, you didn't look at the paper when he gave it to you."

Ekaete brought out the piece of paper from her bag and unfolded it.

"There it is, I told you he wrote it down."

"Doctor and Mrs. Sagoe."

"The missionary is a doctor!! Nobody told me that they are educated!"

"I don't think he is a medical doctor, anyway when you get there you will find out."

"And the name Sagoe, where are they from?"

"That I don't know, but I know that the wife is from the eastern part of the country. Like I said I don't know them well enough."

"And you are sending your daughter to go and leave with people you don't know?"

"Eka do not make it any more difficult for me than it is. Do you think I'm happy? I'm not, it's all my fault but I know that God will work it out for good."

"Mama, why did a beautiful woman like you marry an illiterate like my father?"

"Don't be disrespectful to your father."

"I'm not being disrespectful; I'm just stating the fact. You dropped out of secondary school, and he only attended primary school. I've always been curious."

"Maybe one day I will tell you, definitely not on a public bus."

They both sat in silence, while their mind roamed. Anne Udoh glanced at her daughter; she has changed so much in the past year she has been away. She was no longer the obedient vivacious girl that left her house a year ago. The girl sitting beside her with a frown has become a petulant and confident young lady. She hoped and prayed she would be welcomed by the Sagoes and that they will be patient and tolerant. She never thought she would one day agree to her daughter going to be a housemaid and for the second time that is exactly what she is doing, even if this arrangement is different. She toyed with the idea of suggesting they go back to their house. No, she didn't want her daughter to go through the psychological trauma she went through herself. It was better she stayed away and have her dignity intact.

They got to the bus stop and disembarked, the bus conductor brought her suitcase from the trunk and pointed to the direction where they would find cars and buses going to Bauchi.

"Be sure to call Pastor as soon as you get there, that way I will know that you arrived safely."

"Mama, I don't have a phone."

"I know, you'll tell them to call Pastor."

"It is very apparent they will call Pastor to tell him I arrived safely. You don't need to tell me."

They got to the place they were directed and the conductors rushed to pick up their suitcase.

"Madam, where you de go?"

"Bauchi, which bus is going to Bauchi?"

"All these buses de go, the station wagons de go there too."

"I will take the station wagon; it will get there faster than the bus."

"Eka, going by car will be more expensive."

"I know mama, Pastor told me I could take a bus or a wagon."

"Alright, as long as you are safe."

"I will be safe."

"Amen, by God's grace, you will get there safely."

Anne waited until other passengers boarded, she waved goodbye to her daughter as the car drove away. Eka returned the wave and settled into her seat. She was determined not to cry. As Anne Udoh



stood and watched the car drive away, tears of frustration rolled down her cheeks. She has been holding down the tears since her daughter said she was letting her go away to live with strangers a second time. She felt unworthy, she has failed as a mother, and she could only pray her daughter and her unborn child will have a better life than she.

## Chapter Sixteen

Jane sat at the dining table with her father and David after her mother left. She knew that her mother was trying to protect somebody but at the same time, she was not sure about it and didn't know how to get to the truth without accusing anybody. David sat a little while and went to watch a movie, his mind was in turmoil though he tried to keep a straight face. He felt like going to his room but knew it would be out of place and would raise eyebrows, Jane was already suspicious, and he didn't want to fuel her suspicion. His father watched his every move and wasn't fooled by his act of innocence, he also knew that trying to prove his guilt would be counterproductive. Jane thought up another line of action instead of trying to get her parents to find Eka.

"Daddy I would like to work this vacation; I don't want to stay idle for three months before the next academic year. Can you help get me a firm to work in?"

"I'd rather you stay with Julia and Jake now that the house help is gone, they need company."

"They will manage without me; they were doing fine before I came back. Mummy should have thought about that before sending her away."

"I can't think about any firm that can employ you right now. What role would you play in an establishment?"

"I can work in a law firm as a clerk."

"In a law firm, what do clerks do in a law firm?"

"I don't know, they file the cases and run some errands for the lawyers, I guess. I will find out when I get there."

"No, Janie, I think you should stay home and keep your younger one's company. You will also help with the cooking and all, I don't want another housemaid in this house."

"Daddy, I can't do all that, I need a job."

"Housework is a good job, it's about time you learned all about it."

"No, Daddy I don't want to stay at home."

"Don't worry, work at home and I will pay you a salary. Is that okay with you?"

Jane frowned without answering. Staying at home won't serve her purpose, neither would disobeying her father.

"I will get you a new laptop to boot. You can also help me research some of the topics I will teach my team members. You'll have a lot of things to keep you busy in the house."

Jane reluctantly accepted her father's proposal. She missed Eka who has become like a sister to her. She will find a way to track her down no matter how long it takes.

"Dad, what about me? Where do you think will be the best organization to do my vac job? I need to save money for Uni."

"You have not yet passed JAMB Dave."

"I will pass JAMB dad, the exam was a walkover, there's no way I'm not going to the Uni come September."

"I think I can get one of the departments in my office to employ you."

"No Dad, I don't think it's a good idea to work in your office."

"Why not Dave, you don't want Daddy to know about your escapades?"

"I don't get involved in escapades Jane; I want to work in a place I'll feel free without any staff member watching my every move."

"You have a point there, I will ask my friend, the bank director if he can help get you something to do in the bank while you wait."

"That will be wonderful."

"Daddy, Dave wants to study Engineering, don't you think it will be better if he does a vac job in an engineering firm?"

"I don't want an Engineering firm, I lack the experience for now, after my first year at the Uni, I can take a vac job in such a place, for now, a clerical job in the bank will be best."

"Good night, Daddy." Jane got up to leave.

"Going to bed, it's only 9 o'clock?"

"Yes, Daddy I want to sleep. It has been a long day."

"Alright, good night then, I think I will go to bed too, I have a lot to do at the office tomorrow."

David silently heaved a sigh of relief as his father got up and headed towards his room, he was dreading his father asking him any more questions about Ekaete's pregnancy. At least he could be left alone with his thoughts for now. His emotions were all over the place. He missed

Eka and at the same time was grateful she was gone; he couldn't imagine coming home and facing the possibility of being the father of her child. It was unimaginable for him to be a father at eighteen.

Ekaete disembarked from the vehicle and looked around anxiously, her stomach rumbling. She slept all through the journey and was a bit disoriented when the passenger beside her nudged her awake as they drove into the motor park. She went around to the trunk and brought out her suitcase and stood beside the car. A light-skinned woman approached the vehicle and smiled at her.

"You must be Eka, right?"

"Yes, ma."

"I'm Mrs. Sagoe. Welcome to Bauchi, come with me, my husband is in the car waiting."

Eka followed as she led the way to a blue Toyota Camry just outside the motor park. Eka greeted the man behind the wheel who said a brief hello and she climbed into the back of the car at the prompting of the woman.

"You look tired, did you have something to eat on the way?"

"I had a cup of tea in the morning."

"It's that all you've had since morning?"

"Yes, ma."

"No, that's not good, you should feed well." She turned to her husband.

"Fred, I think we should get some fruit juice and snacks for Eka, it's going to be a long drive to Bindu, she needs to eat something."

"Snacks and fruit juice is not food."

"I know, it's better than nothing. We can't buy food on the road."

"Okay."

Fred made a U-turn and went back to the motor park as it was the only place they could buy the juice and snacks. Ekaete accepted the juice and biscuits and sat back on the seat to drink the refreshing pineapple juice. The couple looked much younger than she imagined. She didn't know what to think about them, the woman looked nice, but her husband seemed aloof. She must remember they are Christians and would be different from the Daniels. They made the journey to Bindu almost in

silence. The Sagoes live in a three-bedroom bungalow on a lonely hill village. Their house was the only brick house in the village, it looked like the biblical city on a hill, only it was not a city in any sense. The villagers Eka glimpsed on their drive to the hill house were scantily dressed. Many of the children were naked and barefooted.

"Welcome to our house, Eka. I hope you'll be happy here. I will show you to your room, you will freshen up while I make dinner."

She led the way to the spare room and opened the door and waved Eka in. "Make yourself comfortable. I will call you when dinner is ready."

Ekaete looked around the sparsely furnished room. There was a bed and a table and a vinyl carpet. Another door in the room was slightly open, she peeped in and saw it was a bath and toilet. There was a towel and toiletries all set out. She has a bath and toilet all to herself, she couldn't believe it. She stepped back and put her suitcase on the bed, quickly unzipped it and hung the few dresses in the wardrobe and went to have a quick bath. A few minutes later, she went to join her hostess in the kitchen. She was cooking spaghetti and chicken with vegetables.

"You are here already, can you cook?"

"Yes ma, I started cooking when I was eleven years old."

"Oh yea, I guess I should have known that since you were living with some people before."

At the mention of that, Ekaete become a little uncomfortable, she didn't know if the Sagoes knew her story. She stepped out into the dining to set the table. When her hostess was done dishing the food, she helped carry the dishes to the table. Mr. Sagoe was already seated in the dinning as they brought in the last dish. They all sat down to eat. Fred said a brief prayer and they all ate in silence. After dinner, Mrs. Sagoe turned to Ekaete. "We have not had a proper introduction; my name is Grace, and my husband is Fred. He is from Ghana and I'm from Imo State. We met at the University of Ghana as young Christians. We belonged to the same Christian group on campus, we got married a few years after graduation. As you've been told, we are missionaries, we came here to share the gospel of Jesus." She paused briefly.

"I guess you will be part of our mission field, when you are converted, you too can bring others to the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ."

Ekaete nodded and said nothing.

"You go ahead and wash the dishes and you can go to bed after that. It's been a long day, tomorrow we will talk more."

When she was done washing the dishes, she went to the living room to bid them good night. Esther picked up a package on the table.

"Do you have a cell phone?"

"No ma."

"Here's a phone for you. Do you know how to set it up?"

No, ma."

"You've never owned a phone before?"

"No ma."

"Fred, can you help set it up for her?" She turned to her husband.

"No, she can set it up herself.

Ekaete read the manual and try setting it up.

You look like a reasonably intelligent young lady, if you find it difficult, tomorrow I can help. I believe you can figure it out."

"Thank you, ma, thank you, sir," Eka said on bended knees as Esther handed her the package.

She went into her room and sat on the bed. She looked around and smiled to herself; for the first time in her life, she has a room to herself, she sat at the table and ate with adults, and the missionaries addressed her as an adult. For the first time in her life, she felt like an adult who had value. And she now has a phone to boot. She made up her mind to be at her best living with the Sagoes.

## Chapter Seventeen

Esther Daniels came back from her job and knocked on the door, Julia opened the door and Esther was horrified. 'Julia, I've told you before never to open the door, you don't know who it might be at the door, it could be a kidnapper. Where is Jane, what is she doing allowing you to open the door?'

"Jane is not here. She went out in the morning and hasn't come back."

"Since morning?" She asked incredulously.

"Yes, Mummy."

"Jake, is it true?"

"Yes, mummy." He answered without taking his eyes off his game on the TV.

"You mean it has just been the two of you home alone since morning?"

"Yes, mummy."

"Have you eaten?"

"Yes, we ate breakfast and she put our lunch in the flask and asked us to eat when we are hungry."

"Did she tell you where she was going?"

"No, she left with a bag. I saw her folding her cloth into the bag."

Esther couldn't believe what she just heard, she walked briskly into Jane's room, and sure enough, the traveling bag was not at its usual place on top of the chest of drawers. She looked at her wristwatch, it was 5.45 pm.

"What time did she leave Julia?"

"About ten O'clock."

Esther reached for her phone and called her husband and narrated what her younger kids told her, and he listened without uttering a word.

"You are not alarmed that your daughter left the house without telling anybody?"

"Jane called me a few minutes ago and told me she is in Abuja."

"What, she went to Abuja? To do what?"

"Your guess is as good as mine, she went to look for Ekaete."

"What, she doesn't know where she lives, how in the world does she think she's going to locate her? As far as I know, her house doesn't have an address."

"We'll talk about that when I come back, I'm almost home."

Emma came up the stairs and Esther was standing right at the door.

"What does that girl think she is doing, how did she get the money, how could she travel to Abuja all by herself?"

"Teenagers today know more than you do at fifty."

"Did she tell you where she is at? Is she alright?"

"She took a flight to Abuja and took a taxi to Sheraton Hotel, that's where she is right now."

"What, how come she can afford to stay at Sheraton?"

"It seems like she saved all the money I paid her these past few weeks to be able to make the trip."

"This is unbelievable. I can't believe Jane can do this."

"Relax Esther, we are going to Abuja tomorrow, she said if we don't come to Abuja, she won't come back home. And she only has money to stay in Sheraton for two days."

Esther flopped down on the couch; her lies were about to blow up in her face. If her husband and daughter find out the truth, it would be a bad egg on her face.

"What in the hell is that girl thinking? Why does she think she can force anybody to go looking for Eka?"

"I think we should go and sort this out and have a closure. I guess that's what she wants to do before going back to school."

"I think you should go alone Emma; I'm not going."

"You are going with me Esther, this should be a women's thing, you are not leaving me in the middle of it, besides, your daughter said you must come and get her."

With that Emma went to his room to pack a bag. Esther got up slowly and followed her husband.

"Mummy, who will stay with us when you and Daddy travel?"

"I will call your aunty, Nomso to come and stay with you."

"Why not tell David to come and stay with us."



"David is at the University, he can't come home now, he left a week ago. Don't you want to stay with your aunt?"

"It is okay mummy, will she come tonight?"

"No, I will call her now. Don't worry, I think she will come before we leave tomorrow."

Mr. and Mrs. Daniels arrived Sheraton hotel at 3 p.m. and Jane was standing in front of the Sheraton hotel waiting. The hustle and bustle in front of the hotel were a bit unnerving for her. There was nobody her age in the crowd of people going in and out of the hotel. The people she saw were mostly well-dressed grown men and women who were there for serious business. She knew nothing about the hotel except what she saw on TV. She made her reservation on the phone but was awed by what she saw when she got there. She couldn't wait to leave and was grateful when she saw her parents disembarking from the unpainted taxi. She braced herself for the scolding that was coming. All she got was a withering look from her mother and an expressionless look from her father.

Her father said a brief "Let's go" and they all boarded the same taxi to Ekaete's house. They saw her mother seated on the bench beside the house. She made no move to stand up and welcome them.

"Good afternoon, Mrs. Udoh."

"Good afternoon, Sir you are welcome."

She made room on the bench for them to sit down.

"Where is Eka, we came to see her. This is my daughter Jane; she wants to see Eka."

"Welcome my daughter", she said to Jane who was looking around waiting to see Eka emerge from somewhere.

"Ekaete is not here."

"Would you send for her please; we came essentially to see her?"

"She is not here, and she is not anywhere around Abuja, as such you will not be able to see her."

"It is important that we see her."

"That will not be possible sir."

"Can you tell us where she is so we can go there and see her?"

"No sir, why is it so important for you to see her."

"We came to ask her who the father of her baby is, it is important to my daughter, it is important to me to know who the father of her baby is and see how we can help."

"Didn't your wife tell you who the father is?"

Mrs. Daniel's heart sank, the moment of truth has come. She has sat through the conversation not saying anything. She looked away from everyone and tried to still her racing heart.

"No, she didn't, that is why we are here. Did Ekaete tell you?"

Mrs. Udo was silent for a few minutes, thinking about what to say.

"Your wife came and dropped off my daughter without saying a word to me as if I'm a nobody and my daughter was worthless. Since she didn't tell you who is responsible for my daughter's pregnancy, I think it is best for everyone if we leave it at that. When Eka gives birth to my grandchild I will take care of her child. We don't need your help."

"Mama, I want Ekaete to be treated with fairness, she is a good girl, that's why we came," Jane spoke up for the first time. She didn't want her trip and the risk she took to be in vain.

"Thank you, my daughter, you are a good girl yourself, Ekaete thinks highly of you. I will let her know you came looking for her."

"Do you have a phone number where I can reach her?"

"No, my daughter, I don't."

"Can I leave my number with you so she can call me?"

"Okay my daughter, write it down for me, I will see that she gets it. Though I don't know if she has access to a phone."

"Are you sure you don't want to send for Eka, we can wait another day or two?"

"No, sir, there is no point waiting."

Mr. Daniel saw the resolve on her face and decided not to push further.

"Okay, when you see her do let her know we came looking for her. And if you change your mind, you know how to reach me."

"Mm, alright sir, thank you."

They got up to leave and Mrs. Udoh sat where she was without seeing them off. Esther Daniel didn't know whether to feel relieved or

angry, she kept silent as they all got into the same taxicab they came with and drove back to the hotel.

"We'll go pick up your suitcase, and we are heading back to Lagos on the 6 o'clock flight. I hope we'll make it to the airport before then."

"But I paid for three nights."

"It is your loss unless you want to stay and come back tomorrow."

No, Daddy."

"Good, you will go and pick up your stuff and check out, we are leaving tonight."

Mrs. Daniel sat through the ride without uttering a word. Jane glanced at her mother's expressionless face and knew it was going to be a long way to reconciliation. Going by the question Eka's mother asked, she suspected her mother knew the father of her unborn child, but she decided to let it go for now.

Anne Udoh looked at the phone number Jane wrote on the piece of paper and tore it and rolled it into a ball praying to God to forgive her for telling the girl she would give it to Eka. She knew it will be better for everyone to end the matter there. Her daughter made a mistake, there was no point complicating anybody else's life. God will take care of her daughter.

"It is well." She said aloud to herself.

## Chapter Eighteen

Nwafor and Katie Elugo boarded the eighteen-seater bus to Goza on the last lap of their journey. Earlier they had taken a flight from Enugu to Abuja. The bus was the only available transportation to the VVF hospital. As they drove through the bumpy dusty road Katie said a prayer for strength and courage and tried not to question her decision to come on this voluntary work. It was Amaka's idea that they come to Nigeria, and Katie had agreed enthusiastically. Amaka made all the travel arrangements and got the necessary permits they needed as well as the liaison with their sponsors. They were on a fact-finding mission to the VVF hospitals. They plan to visit two or three of them and decide what is needed and how they and others can help.

"It's so quiet and dark on this road 'Maka, I hope we are safe."

"Relax Katie, we will be fine. Our hosts will be waiting for us at the bus stop. There's no need to be uneasy."

"Maybe we should have asked a male colleague to accompany us on this trip".

"Easy Katie, I hope you are not having a rethink about this because it could be worse."

"What do you mean by that?"

"Nothing in particular. That's just my way of bracing up for any eventuality. You should do the same. Remember we discussed the challenges we might face, we are doing God's work, He is watching over us, so banish that look of anxiety from your face."

"You are not worried that we are the only foreigners on this bus and this unknown territory?"

"I did my research well. We are properly dressed and look respectable."

At the mention of their dressing, Katie glanced at her green kaftan and trouser and smiled. They both wore black trousers with green shirt tops that reached well below their knees. They looked more like volunteer EPI officers than medical doctors. It was Amaka's idea that

they dress that way and now she knew why. They made the rest of the journey in silence.

By the time they got to the VVF hospital in Goza, it was quite dark. The bus stopped a few meters from the hospital. As they disembarked from the bus, the rest of the passengers observed them in silence. The bus conductor handed them their bags from the trunk and drove off. Katie stamped her feet on the ground to get the blood circulating again on her stiff legs, while Amaka looked around to see if anybody was waiting to escort them to the centre. There was nobody in sight. They saw the centre a little distance away from the bus stop.

"Well, well, well, I can't see any welcoming party for us."

"I guess we must escort ourselves to the centre. I hope they will take us to the living quarters as soon as possible because I'm about to drop."

They walked to the hospital in silence.

"Congrats Katie, you made it this far, for a moment I thought I may have to carry you the rest of the way to our destination."

"Glad you noticed I was almost wobbling."

At the gate, the security officer directed them to the office of the head of administration. They got to the door of the office and knocked; a short stocky man showed his face behind the door.

"Come on in Dr. Amaka and Dr. Katie. You are welcome to Goza. He opened the door wide with a welcoming smile and shook their hands warmly.

"I'm sorry nobody was at the bus stop to welcome you. You arrived earlier than we thought you would. Please do sit down."

"My name is Dr. Chris Rigin and I would like to welcome you to Goza VVF Hospital on behalf of my staff."

"Thanks doctor."

The director went round to sit down on his chair as both ladies took the seats offered them.

"I'm glad to have you both here. I was quite surprised and happy when I received your letter offering us a voluntary service. It is the first of such offers in this hospital and we appreciate it. Though I'm still curious why you chose a hospital in this rural area. All the same, we are happy you

did. We promise to provide as much comfort as we can afford to ensure that you enjoy your stay here.”

“Thank you, doctor,” they responded.

They were both amused at the man’s voice which belied his looks. Dr. Rigin was short and stocky with broad shoulders. He filled the chair he sat on. He had large eyeballs that looked larger behind his double-lens eyeglasses. He looked every inch a formidable man but with a feminine voice.

Dr. Rigin stared briefly at both young women. They looked much younger than he expected, and they were pretty. It was heart-warming to have such young people on his team.

“I can see you are worn out from the long journey. My secretary will show you to your living quarters, tomorrow we will continue with the other formalities.”

“Okay Doc and thank you once again.”

“You are welcome.”

The secretary walked them to their living quarters after a brief exchange of greetings. She walked briskly in front of them. It seemed like she had overstayed her work period and was in a hurry to go home. They tried to match her pace. Katie seemed to have drawn some strength from the warm welcome they received from Dr. Rigin.

They were shown into a sparsely furnished two-bedroom bungalow. To their surprise, the secretary switched on the electric bulbs and the light came on. Amaka and Katie looked at each other. They were expecting lanterns to be lit. The secretary showed them around the house and left. Each of the rooms had its bathroom and toilet and everywhere was lit up. Three armchairs and a reading table dotted the sitting room. Someone must have tried dusting the furniture but did not do a good job of it. The doctors were happy at what they saw. It was like finding an oyster on the shores of a shallow stream. They expected a tiny hut with raffia rooftops and a lantern. They quickly had a cold bath and lay down to sleep off their exhaustion. They were too tired to think about food.

Amaka woke up early in the morning and dressed up in her slacks to take a walk as was her everyday exercise regime. Katie stayed

back. She walked briskly around the hospital. The VVF hospital comprised six buildings. Four of the buildings faced each other in a square shape. The doctor's consulting rooms, the administrative block were a few meters away from the patients' wards. Their living quarters, as she noticed earlier, were a part of two other detached bungalows built in a straight line. She has not seen the occupants of the other flats yet.

The weather was cool this morning and she enjoyed the cool morning breeze on her skin. She soaked in the clean air as much as she could by taking deep breaths. She knew the cool air will give way to a sweltering hot day. She had read up as much information as she could about Goza and other towns in the state. She tried to remember all she read about the weather, the people, the culture, and the food. At the thought of food, she realized she had not had a good meal for the past twenty-four hours and she has not seen any cafeteria around.

She walked back to the house. Katie was up and in the kitchen. She had two open cans of baked beans on the kitchen table.

"Mm, what do we have here?"

"A stove, a matchbox, a table, and three cooking pots," Katie replied smiling. "I guess we will have to live on canned foods till we get used to the food around here."

"Yeah, thank God we came with some, thank you Katie for coming with me."

"You are welcome 'Maka. It looks like I might like it here, better than I thought."

"We better hurry up and be at the director's office before he arrives."

"Yea, we can't wait to hear some ringing, can we?" They both laughed.

## Chapter Nineteen

They dressed up in knee-length skirts and flowered shirts and put on their doctor's overalls and headed towards Dr. Rigin's office. The doctor was unlocking his office door as they both walked down the corridor. He was an early riser. Nobody else was in sight. They smiled their good morning as he ushered them into his office.

"We did not have a proper introduction last night. I am Dr. Amaka Okafor and my friend and colleague here is Dr. Katie Elugo. I'm a gynaecologist and Katie is a urologist; we came on a health mission so to speak. I heard some information about this hospital and chose to come and see how we can help."

"Yes, I read that from the file sent from the Federal Ministry of Health and your host organization. I must confess I couldn't place the names last night."

"Yea, we guessed."

"Tell me how you got to know about Goza and why did you choose to do your mission work here?"

"I watched a documentary on YouTube about the prevalence of VVF in Nigeria and after some consultations, I felt I could help one way or the other. I asked my friend Katie to come along, so here we are."

"And this is the second VVF hospital we are visiting. We were at Abaka for a month, we are here now." Katie proffered.

"That is interesting. What exactly do you intend to do here? Sorry, it looks like an interrogation, the letter I got wasn't strong on specifics."

"It's okay, we would like to see the patients, consult and care for them, and make recommendations for funding from our partner organizations."

"We are in consultation with some non-profit organizations that raise funds for medical treatment for patients in developing countries."

"From what I see in the letters I received your consulate is aware of your stay here."

"Of course, they do." Both said in unison.



"I see, you are welcome to my team, and my team includes Dr. Zainab Shuaib and Dr. Amina Buba, they will be here shortly. There's also Dr. Lizzy Idris, an intern, six nurses, and six ward maids. You will get to meet some of them on their morning shift at the nurses' station. I double as the chief liaison officer and the medical director of this facility."

"You mean there are about four doctors for sixty patients?" Amaka asked surprised.

"Yes, that is why you should be prepared, we literally work round the clock, but with both of you on board we can now work shifts, even if it's for two months; I understand that's how long you intend to stay."

"Why are there only three doctors on your team doctor? Is there a scarcity of doctors in Nigeria?"

"As you can see, Goza is in a remote area with harsh weather conditions. Most doctors who come here hardly stay longer than three months except those of us who are tough. I do hope you are tough doctors."

Amaka and Katie exchanged glances.

"Again, because of the religious practice, only female doctors can consult and treat the patients."

"We know that from our research; does that mean that your job here is purely administrative?"

"Yes and no. Regarding VVF treatment, I do not see the patients, we do have outpatient consulting which includes male patients and babies, that's where my medical practice comes in."

Before they could say anything else, the door behind them opened and three female doctors walked in.

"May I introduce Dr. Amaka Okafor and Dr. Katie Elugo? Meet Drs. Zainab, Amina, and Lizzy, my colleagues."

They exchanged pleasantries with the doctors, and they went out to their different consulting rooms.

Doctor Ringin continued with a short brief on how the hospital functioned and took them on a tour of the hospital and on their first ward round to see the patients.

"The VVF wards are four in number and the patients are assigned to wards according to the severity of their cases. There are fifteen patients in each ward."

The doctors filed into ward A. The occupants were mostly young girls. Though the windows were open, the stench of urine was strong. The visiting doctors braced themselves, they had expected much worse. Amaka tried to control her facial features not to show her discomfort. Some of the patients sat on the beds while some lay down. Their chattering stopped as soon as the doctors walked in. Those who were not in their beds went back to sit down. All eyes were fixed on the newcomers. Dr. Rigin addressed the patients in their local dialect. Amaka did not understand what was said but guessed it was an introduction. She looked closely at the faces on the beds.

“Good morning young lady what is your name?” The pretty girl smiled back at Amaka and said nothing. That took the form of the exchange they had with the rest of the patients in Ward A.

“Some of the beds are unoccupied, have the patients been discharged?”

“No, maybe some are outside praying or washing up. We started the ward round a little early today. They will come in before we finish the round.”

Ward B looked very much the same as the other ward. The floor was clean, and the walls were newly painted but were already coated with dust. Streams of the early morning sun filtered in through the open windows. The patients in Ward B looked more at ease. Several of them were chatting. A few of the beds were empty. Just like the other patients, they regarded the newcomers with interest. Amaka glanced around the ward.

“The patients in this ward are the newest cases we have. Most of them have not spent up to a week in this facility and they are trying to adjust to their new surroundings. Some are yet to know the severity of their condition.”

“I see.”

“Gud morning dectar Rigin.”

The three doctors turned to the sound of the first greeting in English from a patient.

“Good morning, Aisha, how are you today?”

“I’m fine dectar.” Amaka turned and stared into the pretty eyes of Aisha, who stood at the entrance of the ward.

"This is Aisha, one of our most interesting patients."

Amaka smiled at the girl. She glanced at Katie who also had a smile on her face. Aisha walked to her bed and sat down still staring at the young doctors.

"What about her baby? The crib beside her bed is empty."

"Maybe she is with a cleaner outside. The cleaners love to stay with her baby."

They made the round to wards C and D where Amaka and Katie saw some of the worst cases of VVF. Most of the patients urgently needed surgery. With the tour of the facility completed, the visiting doctors did not see any theatre. They went back to Ringin's office.

"Doctor Rigin, am I correct to say that this facility is strictly a VVF management facility, not a hospital? I don't see a theatre anywhere."

Katie asked.

"Yes, you can say that. I can guess why you asked the question. We do not cure VVF here, as you know the procedure is quite expensive and most of the patients cannot afford the cost."

"I understand there are hospitals where corrective surgeries are performed."

"Yes, there are about three of them and they are funded by the government, local and foreign non-profit organizations."

"What about information? Are there sustained information programs given to young women of this vulnerable age bracket to avoid the incidence of VVF?"

"Yes, there is, but I must confess it is not nearly enough. Besides, tradition and religious beliefs are impediments to the effort made by the government and non-profits."

"Don't you think women groups from the communities should be actively involved in passing on such information?"

Dr. Rigin was amused at the question. Women groups from the local communities, what do they know about VVF?"

Amaka sat there listening to the exchange and mentally noting down what their first line of action would be. The fact that there was no doctor's shift in existence bothered her. Every doctor was on call at

every hour. She would work towards changing that as soon as possible. Doctors need rest to give their best to the patients.

"Since we are here now Doctor, I think we should draw up a roaster for the doctors, shouldn't we?"

"That is alright with me. I will give you the names of the nurses and ward maids also. And you can call me Chris."

"We would also like to see the database of the patients to know their medical history and stages of their diseases and know who needs urgent attention."

Chris smiled again and Amaka was a little embarrassed, she asked the question without thinking, there was no computer in sight.

"We don't have computers and a database as of now, you will have to check their files manually. My secretary will give you the files as soon as you want to start with them".

"I'm sorry doctor I should have noticed that."

"It is okay, the name is Chris."

"Alright Chris, we came with an extra laptop, we would like to donate it to the hospital."

"That's alright with me."

"Is your secretary computer literate?"

"Yes, she is but since she has not been working with a computer for quite a while, she would need some help."

"Of course, we will set it up and help her out wherever she needs help."

"Alright then, I will show you to your office so you can get started."

Dr. Rigin led the way to a room three doors away from his office. The room was partitioned with finely polished mahogany wood. A table and a chair faced each other from two ends of the room. One examination table was partially curtained off at the end of the room close to the polished wood. The carpet on the floor has endured many feet and the design on it was barely visible. A ceiling fan whirled above them.

"Here we are doctors, I hope you like it here. Dr. Lizzy and the head nurse are your neighbours on the other side of the partition. Their entrance door is on the other side. My secretary is available to you any

time you need her and so am I. I will leave you to get down to what you need to do today."

"Thanks Doc." He turned and left, closing the door behind him. Amaka and Katie took the wipes in their bags and wiped down the tables and chairs and sat down to discuss their goals and strategies on how to help the organization.

"Wow, what a day" Katie flopped down on the bed with her bath towel tied around her. She had just had a cold bath. "What a day," she said again. Amaka sat on the bed with her nightgown on.

"It's not too bad for a first day in the middle of nowhere."

"I can't believe it could be this hot in this part of our country."

"Well, we are discovering our country all the way from another continent."

"Wow, sweet rest," Katie said as she curled up on the bed ready to fall asleep.

"I hope you are not planning to sleep with your towel, girlfriend?"

"You watch me. I sprinkled the towel with water to keep me cool during the night. I don't want the heat to interrupt my sleep."

"You are unbelievable. Are you that hot?"

"Of, course I am, aren't you?"

"I am, but not enough to sleep in a wet towel."

"Well, I'm sleeping in one. It is part of the experience of discovering our fatherland."

Amaka got up and went to the table and opened her laptop.

"What are you doing 'Maka?"

You know one of the interesting things about this country is the good communication network. You can make calls from anywhere."

"Yeah, the communication companies are doing a great job. Do hurry up 'Maka and turn off the light, I can't sleep well with the lights on."

"Okay, I won't take more than ten minutes. I want you to stay awake and keep me company as I write."

"It is my snores that will keep you company, you just wait for it."

Amaka smiled as she typed her mail and waited for the snores that didn't come.

## Chapter Twenty

"Hi Aisha, do you speak English?"

"A little."

"But you do understand English, don't you?"

"Yes," Aisha nodded her head, elated that the new doctor showed a special interest in her.

"Okay, what is your daughter's name?"

"Laraba"

"Mm, she looks lovely just like you. What would you like to do when you leave the hospital? That is when you get well."

Aisha touched her ear and motioned with her hands to show she didn't understand the question. The accent was strange to her. Amaka looked at the nurse to help her translate the question. She returned a blank look. Amaka repeated the question slowly.

"What would you like to do when you leave the hospital? Would you like to go to school?"

At the mention of school, Aisha's eyes lit up and her interest peeked. She answered an animated "Yes."

The other patients listened to the exchange between Aisha and the doctor with interest without understanding what was being said. They felt it must be interesting since Aisha was smiling and nodding her head.

"At which grade did you drop out of school?"

Aisha stared at the doctor trying to figure out what she meant.

"Primary six," she answered at last.

Amaka noticed that Aisha's eyes came alive as they talked about school, which meant that she loved being in school. She tried chatting with other patients but made no headway since they did not understand a word of what she said. She and Katie made notes of some of the cases in their notebooks.

From what they read from the patient's files and their observations on the ward rounds, they figured that almost all the cases among the young girls were the same; they all had prolonged labour, unsterilized

and crude incisions. A few isolated cases among the older women were a little more complicated.

She asked Katie to redo the roster so that going forward they would do the ward rounds with one other doctor or the intern to enable them to interact better with the patients. The nurses couldn't understand their English accents any more than the patients did.

A blue Toyota Camry car stopped in front of the outpatient ward and a light-skinned young lady alighted from the car accompanied by a couple. Amaka and Kate looked at each other as they walked towards the consulting room. They had just finished the morning ward round and were walking back to the consulting room.

"This is the first time I've seen a car on this premises except Dr. Riggins of course."

"That's right, I wonder why they are here, the girl doesn't look sick."

"We'll find out soon enough, they will send her to us, I'm sure."

The girl and the couple walked towards the receptionist as the doctors walked into the consulting room. The girl looked around the waiting room as the receptionist brought down a long notebook from the shelf and wrote on it. The new patient surmised that she was the first person to arrive at the centre that morning.

"Menini suna ki?"

"What?"

"You don't speak Hausa?"

"No."

"What's your name?"

"My name is Ekaete Udoh."

"Can you spell that for me?"

"Yes."

The receptionist wrote down the name.

"How old are you?"

"A little over sixteen."

The receptionist wrote it down and stood up.

"Please come with me."

Ekaete followed her to a small cubicle where a nurse sat with a sphygmomanometer hanging on her neck. The nurse took her vital

statistics without questions and took her to the consulting room where Amaka and Kate sat.

"Good morning, Doctors." Ekaete smiled at the two doctors.

"Good morning, sit down." Amaka pointed her towards Katie's table. Katie looked at the girl surprised. She sat down across the table.

"Your name is Ekae.."

"Ekaete, you can call me Eka for short."

"Alright Eka, what's wrong with you?"

"I went into early labour when I was home alone. I wanted to go and look for help nearby, but in my haste, I fell and landed on my buttocks. The baby's head was almost out by the time I was taken to the health clinic."

"It's good you came to the hospital early. Who are the couple that brought you to the hospital?"

"They are my guardian; they are Christian missionaries."

"Is that your baby with the lady?"

"Yes."

"I see, is there a health clinic around here?"

"There's a health clinic, but it's quite a distance from here."

Katie pointed her to the examination table and examined her as she asked her some questions about her pregnancy and delivery.

"You have an obstetrics tear. There is no infection because you came to the hospital early. We will have to admit you into the hospital and see how we can arrange a corrective surgery as soon as possible. Your case is not as serious as the ones I have seen."

"Okay, I will inform my guardian."

"Ask them to come in with you, I would like to have a word with them."

As soon as she stepped out, Katie turned to Amaka.

"Great, now we have one patient who can speak English. She will be our interpreter in our interactions with the patients."

"Yeah, she will be our voice. I do hope she understands and speaks Hausa."

"We will find out if the missionary church is close by, I would like to go to church, I've not been to any since we came here."



"We will do that, I'm missing church too, but if we can't go there, we will continue to pray by ourselves. God is with us wherever we worship him."

Ekaete came in with Grace and Fred Sagoe, and they all sat down. Katie explained Eka's case to them and why she will need to be admitted.

"How long will she be here?"

"I don't know yet, but we will try to get her the surgery she needs as fast as we can."

"You know, I'm surprised to see they do have expatriate doctors at this hospital," Grace said with an appreciative smile.

"We are not expatriate doctors in that sense, we are here on a medical mission."

"That's interesting. We are missionaries, and our host mission is affiliated with a church in Texas."

"That's nice, is your church close by? We would like to attend; we've not been to church in a while."

"It's not that close, we drove about two hours to get here."

"Oh wow, we can't go that far, we are not mobile."

"That's alright, we'll be praying for you."

"We can come and pick you up for service any Sunday you want, you just let us know in time and be up early." Fred offered.

Oh, thank you, Pastor.

"Fred Sagoe. I'm Fred and my wife is Grace."

"It's nice to meet you."

"Same here."

"Can we have your numbers please?"

"Yes, of course." Fred gave them his number and that of his wife.

"We'll keep in touch."

"Okay, hope to see you soon."

Ekaete left the consulting room with her guardian and they headed to the car. "We will come back to check on you tomorrow and bring some more of the essentials you will need while you are here. Don't worry about Joshua, he'll be fine. He will have to do with infant formula till you are discharged".

“Thank you, ma.” Ekaete opened the trunk and took her bag and some beverages. She came prepared because Grace already told her she might be admitted to the centre. The Sagoes said their goodbyes and left. Eka walked back to the waiting area to wait for the nurse who would take her to her ward.

## Chapter Twenty-One

"Good morning doctor."

"Good morning Eka, how are you holding up?"

"Fine, I'm getting used to my new surroundings."

"And your roommates?"

"I'm getting to know them as well, only we can't communicate."

"Don't you understand a little of the language?"

"I do, but I can't speak it, it has not been long since I came to this part of the country."

"Give it some time, you will soon start speaking it now that you are in the company of people who can't understand you. By the way, there's a girl in ward B who can speak some. Maybe you can visit her sometimes and help her brush up on her English, who knows she can become your interpreter while you are here."

"Okay, I will. Eh, doctor you said I will need corrective surgery, how soon can it be done?"

"We are making arrangements for that, as soon as we are ready, we will let you know."

"Alright, thanks doctor."

"You are welcome."

As soon as the doctors left the ward, Ekaete went in search of the girl in Ward B. She did not ask the name of the girl. She will have to find out somehow. She walked to ward B and stood at the entrance door.

"Who can speak and understand English in this ward, can you indicate by raising your hand, I have an announcement to make."

Fifteen pairs of eyes looked towards the door where she stood, but nobody replied. Eka stepped backwards and looked at the top of the door to make sure she was in the right place. Ward B was written boldly above the pane. She walked in again and smiled at every girl on each bed and introduced herself. She wasn't sure anybody understood her and she felt like an alien. Some smiled back at her, some regarded her with disdain. As she came by Aisha's bed, she smiled back, "My name is Aisha."

"Wow, that's a relief, I was beginning to despair in my search. Why didn't you answer my question the first time I came in?"

Aisha smiled and didn't reply.

"Okay let's say you didn't want to be an omo English"

"What that mean?"

"Mm, never mind."

Eka smiled at Aisha's baby. "Your baby is beautiful just like you."

"Her name is Laraba."

"Laraba, what does that mean?"

"It means Wednesday."

"That means she was born on a Wednesday."

"Yes, you in this hospital?"

"Yes, I was admitted yesterday."

"Where your baby?"

"He is not here with me."

"Why you ask if anybody speaks English."

"I wanted somebody to chat with. Imagine being in the midst of girls your age and you cannot communicate!"

"What is comucate?"

"Communicate, you cannot talk with each other."

"But you say you..."

"I have an announcement to make. I was kidding. Tell me about yourself, Aisha."

Aisha spent some time telling Eka her story. Eka tactfully declined to tell hers. Before Ekaete left she had made friends with four other girls with the help of Aisha. Soon Eka became popular in the teenage wards. Some inmates admired her vivacity while some saw her as being intrusive and ignored her completely.

A few weeks after Eka was admitted to the hospital, she sought out Aisha.

"Aisha come let's go and visit the foreign doctors."

"Ha, visit doctors? they don't like it."

Aisha waved two fingers at Ekaete to emphasize her disagreement.

"You mean they don't like it, or they might not like it? I'm sure you have not visited them before."

Aisha shook her head and fingers again. Eka grabbed her right hand.

"Come let's go now that your baby is sleeping. We can only find out if they like the visit or not when we get there."

"Why you want visit them?"

"I want to ask them some questions."

"Ask them when they come to ward."

"No, I won't have time to ask them the questions during the ward round."

"No, I no go."

"Come, what are you afraid of?"

Aisha allowed herself to be dragged away from the corridor of her ward and went with her new friend.

Amaka and Katie were reclining on their camp beds in front of their house in the warm evening. They sat up as the girls approached them hesitantly. Eka walked up to them and greeted them. Aisha stood a few meters away.

"Come, Aisha, why are you standing there?" Aisha came closer.

"Well, well, well, to what do we owe this August visit?"

Eka gave her charming smile, and Aisha widened her eyes at Ekaete.

"We came to visit you and learn a few things. Can we sit on the pavement?"

"Yeah, do sit down."

"Thanks."

Katie lay back on the camp bed and closed her eyes, leaving the girls to talk with Amaka. Aisha stared at Katie's legs and that of Amaka. They both wore shorts and sleeveless sheer tops. She looked around to see if someone else was nearby. What if somebody passed by and saw them exposing their bodies?

"Why are you frowning Aisha?" Aisha caught herself and tried rearranging her expression.

"My guess is she is disapproving of your mode of dressing. Aren't you Aisha?"

"O Yeah? I thought you once lived in the city Aisha, didn't you see women dressed this way?"

Aisha didn't answer, she threw an irritated look at Eka for exposing her thoughts.

"Okay Aisha, we are dressed this way because we are feeling hot, and where we come from, it's normal to dress this way during summer, okay."

"Alright, doctor." Aisha was happy to drop the subject.

"Eh m, doctor, I want to ask you some questions."

"Go ahead Eka I'm listening."

"What is VVF and why are we suffering from the disease and how can we be cured and how can the disease be avoided?"

"That's a three-edged question. I will answer it in three parts. "The reason you have the disease is that you had prolonged labour. During the early teenage years, a woman's pelvis is not properly developed. The pelvis is still growing, if a girl becomes pregnant at this age, she will experience prolonged labour, which if not managed properly, results in VVF. Maybe this diagram will explain it further."

Amaka drew the female birth canal and explained their condition to them. They both listened with rapt attention.

"If this tear is not attended to or managed effectively, it can cause infection and further complications. That is why you are here so that you can get medical care."

"To the second part of the question, the cure can be effected when the torn area is sewn together, and your bladder can once more hold the urine."

She explained the diagram again.

"The condition can be avoided if young girls like you can wait until they are older before they marry or before they have children. By then their reproductive organs would have been fully developed. Again, it can be avoided if there are adequate health care facilities and antenatal care and adequate medical advice for young pregnant girls."

"But doctor, I know that in Western countries, some young unmarried girls do have babies, but they don't suffer from this disease."

"Yes, I already answered that. It is because, during antenatal care, the doctors know if a teenage girl can have her baby without damage or if she would need a caesarean delivery."

“And before you ask, you know that some elderly women also suffer from VVF. It’s the same antenatal care that takes care of that,” Katie proffered.

They were surprised that Katie has been listening to their discussion.

“So, if girls had babies from the age of eighteen and above, they would not have the disease?”

“At least it would reduce the incidence by about seventy percent. The statistics are mine, and that is because seventy-five percent of the cases we have seen are among under-aged girls.”

Aisha listened to the conversation with keen interest. She did not understand most of it but could figure out what was being said at least the basics. She ventured a question of her own.

“Decter, can I be cured too?”

“Of course, Aisha you can be cured.”

“Can I go back to school?”

“Yes, you can go back to school.”

Aisha’s eyes lit up. The possibility of going back to school made her very happy. It didn’t matter that she didn’t know how that could happen.

“Decter, are you marry?”

“Married.”

“Are you married?”

“No, I’m not married.”

Aisha pointed at Katie.

“No Katie is not married as well.”

Aisha shook her head. The ladies could not fathom whether it was in wonder or disapproval.

“Someday I would like to travel outside my country and help others just like you are doing here.”

“Of course, you can Eka if you are determined and focused. There’s no limit to what you can achieve if you are focused. Focus is the important denominator of achievement. Don’t be distracted and don’t allow other people to push you around.”

“Thank you, doctor.”

“You are welcome.

“We want to leave now.”

“Okay, you are welcome to our house any day.”

They hurried back to their wards. Aisha was in high spirits. As soon as she went to her bedside, she blurted out to her roommate. “I will be cured, and I will go back to school.”

They looked at her without comprehension. Aisha didn’t bother to translate. She bent down to carry her baby out of the crib. Her happiness became dampened as she wondered what she would do with her baby in pursuit of her dreams.

“Don’t tell me you want to encourage your patients to visit you at home, it is not proper.”

“What makes it improper Katie?”

“It is not normal or ideal you know that.”

“Sometimes we must bend the rules to be effective. Can’t you see we’ve just started our enlightenment campaign with that visit?”

“I see.”



## Chapter Twenty-Two

"I heard that you've been going around the wards telling the girls to go against their parent's wishes and not to marry."

"That's not true Dr. Zainab, I didn't say any such thing. I only told some of them what Dr. Amaka told us about waiting a little longer before we get married and to be sure we receive proper antenatal care during pregnancy."

"I don't believe you, anyway I came to warn you to desist from spoiling other girls in this hospital. They are not like you. They got married before they had children, and you got pregnant out of wedlock. You are a bad influence, and I would not allow you to contaminate their minds."

"I believe in people being enlightened and knowledgeable Dr. Zainab, if you don't like it, you have to deal with it."

"Who are you addressing like that you spoilt little brat, if you don't stop filling the heads of other girls with nonsense, I will ensure you are discharged from this hospital."

Ekaete turned and walked away in anger, spilling some of the water from her bucket. She was on her way from the well when Dr. Zainab stopped her.

Dr. Zainab stomped to Amaka's office, knocked, and stormed in, not waiting for an answer.

"Hello Dr. Zainab, how are...."

"Dr. Okafor, I heard that you've been telling the patients that their disease is a result of early marriage."

Amaka raised her eyebrows at the anger in the doctor's voice.

"Yes, from research and observation, that's the conclusion that has been reached by experts."

"I see, so the girls shouldn't marry so they don't get VVF, is that it?"

"I'm surprised to hear this from a doctor. You and I know that early teenage birth is the major cause of VVF."

"I don't know that. In my religion and my culture, girls marry early and I won't have anybody putting it in their heads not to obey their religion and their tradition."

"Tell me, how would you, as a doctor check the prevalence of VVF among young girls in your country?"

"As far as I know, VVF is an inexplicable phenomenon. Don't teenage girls have children in America?"

"They do, but they don't end up with VVF. Besides, the number of VVF occurrences in the U.S. is a mere two percent in a country of over 340 million people. This country is one of the countries with the highest prevalence of VVF. And most of the cases are in the North. We came here based on the informed statistics we had on the prevalence of the disease."

"Well, I came to tell you to stop this campaign, it might have consequences."

"I can't believe I'm hearing this from a doctor. Do you read medical journals at all?"

"I read medical journals, Dr. Kate, and most articles on VVF are inconclusive on why the incidence is on the increase."

"I recommend you read volume seven of the Nigerian health journal. "

"I won't have you tell me what to read and what not to read. This is our country and you Americans should allow us to deal with our problems our own way."

"Point of correction, we are citizens of this country too, and we are interested in contributing our quota in solving some of the health issues where we can."

"Our religion stipulates that..."

"Must you bring religion into everything? Let's be realistic here. I don't see anything intrinsically wrong with the idea of asking young girls to wait a little longer after puberty and get some education before they have babies. It will be good for them and their children."

"And of course, save them from some unnecessary suffering from VVF," Katie spoke up.

"Well, I've warned you." With that, Zainab left and banged the door behind her.

"Maka, if a doctor is reacting this way to an opinion, what do you think the uneducated women would think?"

"You never know, they might be a bit more receptive to the idea."

“Are you kidding me? How far can your optimism go? It takes a while for people to change their notions about things, and when it bothers on religion and tradition, it becomes almost impossible.”

“I believe that education and enlightenment can help. When people are made to understand issues like this and how it can help them and their children and generations unborn, they will accept it. All it needs is time.”

“Which we don’t have.”

“At least we are doing something about it.”

“I don’t have good vibes about Dr. Zainab, she could mean real trouble.”

“Relax       Katie,       we       are       in       good       hands.”

## Chapter Twenty-Three

"I'm aching all over and I feel tired."

"Maybe you are overworking yourself."

"I was working long hours in the States than I do here. It's not overwork."

"I hope it's not what I think it is."

"Malaria? No, we took our yellow fever vaccine before we came, it can't be."

"You need rest then, though I can see you won't be able to get it right away."

"Why is that?"

"Eka is on her way here," Katie said pointing through the window. "Do you still think it is proper for your patients to visit you at home?"

"Under normal circumstances, no, but this is hardly a normal circumstance. I like their company and it also allows me to help them focus on what is important. Don't you want them to visit anymore?"

"I'm just concerned that our discussion with them is already sparking off negative reactions."

"It's only the opinion of one person, don't take it out of proportion."

"I think we should stop the interactions; we came here to look for ways to help the patients and upgrade this facility."

"That's what we are doing Katie. We came here to make an impact and effect a change in the lives of people and part of that is providing helpful information."

"Well, 'Maka, I don't want to get into trouble, we both saw how passionate Dr. Zainab was about her belief. I guess it reflects the feeling of other people."

"And we will not cower because of threats, we are not doing anything wrong."

Ekaete's knock interrupted the discussion. Amaka opened the door. After the greetings, Eka went straight to the purpose of her visit.

"Doctor, when are we leaving for the hospital as you informed us?"

"As soon as the paperwork is ready."

"Which day exactly?"

"What is the problem Eka, why the anxious look on your face?"

"Doctor, some of the patients are mean to me. They are calling me names. I don't want to stay here anymore; I want to go home."

"Look here young lady, you don't run away from challenges, you face them head-on and overcome them."

"It is not just about me Doctor. You might be in danger too."

"What are you talking about?"

"One of the newly employed cleaners asked Aisha to tell you to leave this hospital, that this place is no longer safe for you."

"Are you sure? Why didn't Aisha come and tell me herself?"

"She's afraid and she feels I should be the one to let you know, so she came and told me instead."

"What does the cleaner mean by this place not being safe for me?"

"I don't know, that is what Aisha said."

"We are not running away. Let Dr. Zainab bring on whatever she's got."

"I have to go back now Doctor."

"It is alright Eka, I promise you, we will leave here as soon as possible. Meanwhile, try to ignore the taunts."

"Okay Doctor, bye."

"Yeah."

"You see 'Maka as if I knew all of that before she came. That Zainab looks like trouble, I know it."

"What can she do Katie? Think about it, we are here under the protection of the United States. Stop looking so worried and apprehensive."

"I don't feel comfortable with all these at all. We must report this to Dr. Rigin by tomorrow."

"Believe me Katie it's an empty threat designed to make us feel uncomfortable or worse still, to stampede us out of this place, as for me it's not working. Relax Katie, we are safe."

"We must report this to Dr. Rigin, I will call him right away."

"Katie?"

Katie picked up her phone and started dialling the number, but stopped halfway, she would wait till tomorrow. That night she couldn't

sleep, she tossed and turned and eventually got up. She heard footsteps close to the window and tiptoed to the window. She slowly drew the end of the blind aside and looked out. There was nobody in sight. She glanced at Amaka, she was fast asleep. She looked out again trying to see if she can see anybody in the pitch darkness but couldn't see anything. She drew a chair close to the window and sat down clutching her cell phone. She dozed off intermittently, and when her cell phone fell off her hands for the third time, she went to her bed and lay down.

The next day Katie went into Dr. Rigin's office to voice her concerns.

"I told you from your first day in this hospital that you will be safe here, any rumour about an attack is false, I can assure you."

"But Doctor I heard some strange noise outside our window last night, I couldn't sleep after that."

"It must have been the security guards."

"Are there other security guards apart from the one at the entrance gate?"

"Of course, there are, two of them were specifically assigned to guard both of you."

"I haven't seen any before now."

"They were not meant to look obvious."

"I see."

"I hope you do. Anyway, I will investigate the source of the rumour."

"I hope you will protect the girls and the cleaner; nobody needs to know they told us anything."

"I know Katie."

"Alright then, I will go do my job."

Katie left Doctor Rigin's office and he sat back on his chair brooding. One of the cleaners had mentioned the threat to him the day before and he had shrugged it off. Was it possible somebody could be planning to cause trouble? He would have to act fast.

Shortly after Katie left, Amaka went to see Dr. Rigin.

"Doctor, I think we should transfer some of the patients to Abaka Hospital, it's a bigger hospital and the patients will get better care there and would likely get their corrective surgery faster."

“I guess you would want Aisha and Eka to be among those transferred.”

“Yes, doctor.”

“But you do know there are patients who came here well earlier than they did.”

“I know doctor, I would just like to see them well before we leave or at least know that they are on their way to recovery.”

“I will make my recommendation to the Ministry of Health and see how that works out.”

“Thanks doctor, I will appreciate that.”

“You are welcome.”

## Chapter Twenty-Four

Amaka made the ward rounds as usual, by the time she was done, she had a headache and joint pain coupled with a tight squeeze on her stomach. She walked briskly to the outpatient clinic to see the Doctor. The consulting doctor was the intern. She told her the way she was feeling and she recommended a pathological analysis. She went to see Doctor Rigin and told him she would like to take the rest of the day off.

"Alright see me when the result is out and tell the intern to bring your file to me so I will give the prescription myself."

"I'll do that." Amaka went to her office and sat down and pulled out her desk drawer to take her bag.

"Katie, I'm going for a test. This headache and body pain is back, and my stomach is aching as well."

Katie opened her eyes wide and was silent for a while.

"I hope it is not food poisoning."

"Stop being paranoid Katie."

"I'm sorry. Are you taking the day off?"

"Yes, see you later."

An hour later, Amaka went to see Dr. Rigin with the test results in her hand.

"The result says I have traces of salmonella typhi bacteria." She said handing over the result sheet to Doctor Rigin.

"Hm, but it is negligible. A single dose of typhoid medication can take care of it, so I will prescribe the drug."

"I came with my drugs; I think it's a more effective medication for the treatment of typhoid."

Doctor Rigin regarded Amaka for a minute. "That means you came prepared for a possible attack of typhoid."

"One can't be too careful, I didn't rule it out."

"All right, you are a doctor, but I think I'm more knowledgeable about tropical diseases than you do."

"Alright Doctor, you can give me the prescription and I will go get it from the dispensary. I hope I will be back to work by tomorrow."



Amaka went to the dispensary and collected the medication and put it in her bag. She would take the one she came with; she believed it to be more potent.

Katie came in during the lunch break to check in on her and saw her lying on the bed with a fever.

"Maka, I think we should leave for Abuja tomorrow so you can receive proper treatment in a good hospital."

"I will be fine by the time I finish taking this medication. It is still the same drug they will give me there."

"We need to leave Amaka. I can't have you sick, not with the threat from Doctor Zainab and whomever she is plotting with." She said emphatically.

Amaka looked at her friend in surprise, she rarely called her by her full name and she sounded forceful.

"Relax Katie, I will be fine, besides, I cannot leave without the girls. Eka will be in danger if the threat is real. We came here for a purpose, remember?"

"We are not leaving indefinitely; we will come back after a few days when you feel better."

"Don't you know that those who are threatening us would want to ensure that we don't come back?"

Katie was silent for a moment. "You have a point there. That means we need to fast-track the transfer papers."

"Then see to that, will you?"

Katie went back straight to Doctor Rigin's office.

"Doctor, how soon can we get the transfer papers for the girls?"

"I called the Federal Ministry of Health and they have given their approval. That means they can leave as soon as we can arrange transportation for all of you."

"Oh! that's great news. Can we leave tomorrow morning?"

"What's the hurry? I still need to do the paperwork and organize a small get-together to send you off properly."

"I appreciate your thoughtfulness Doc but the send-off won't be necessary, we will come back for that in the future, we just need to leave as soon as the paperwork is ready."

"I think I will have to know Amaka's take on it."

"She is the reason I want us to leave as soon as possible. She has a fever and I want us to leave now that she is still strong."

"Do you think that is a good idea? You should allow her to get better before starting on the road. It's a long journey to Abaka."

"We will be fine."

"Can I give you a piece of advice Katie?"

"Yes Doctor, I'm listening."

"I live in this country, and I know the terrain, believe me when I tell you the idea is not feasible. What I will advise is that you and Amaka should go ahead to Abuja. She will see a doctor and rest for a day or two, and travel to Abaka from there."

"Doctor, you got it all wrong, we plan to go to Abuja first before traveling to Abaka. I didn't mean we are going straight to Abaka."

"I see, that is a better idea."

"What happens to the girls, we wouldn't want to leave without them. My friend will not hear of that."

"You know we are not only transferring just the four patients you want to be transferred. I recommended to the ministry that we transfer the cases that need urgent fistula fixtures to the hospital in Abaka and they approved that as well."

"How many patients are we talking about?"

"They are about twelve in all, so we have arranged for a bus to take all of them to the hospital."

"I'm surprised we are just hearing this now."

"I meant to tell you; nobody knew you might be leaving in a hurry. I remember I mentioned it to Amaka earlier."

"I see. She didn't tell me. When will the patients leave for the hospital?"

"I arranged for them to leave in a week but since you will not wait that long, I'll have to adjust the arrangement to be sooner."

"Thanks Doctor, that's very thoughtful of you. I will go and get our stuff from the office and go and tell Amaka about the new arrangements."

Katie hurried off to their office to pack their medical paraphernalia and left. As Doctor Ringin watched Katie walking to their living

quarters from his office window, he felt a sinking feeling in his stomach. He was going to miss the young doctors.

"Maka, it's all arranged we will leave tomorrow!" Katie was enthused as she walked into the room.

"So soon, are you kidding me?"

"No, I'm not. It appears Doctor Rigin had his own agenda about the whole issue. You know Maka, I feel Doctor Rigin got wind of the rumour too and acted fast on our behalf."

"Maybe, if our leaving can be effected within such a short while, that means the threat may be real."

"You believe it now, don't you?"

"There is still no concrete evidence to prove that. I'm sure Dr. Rigin just acted on what I discussed with him sooner than I thought."

"Believe what you like, I'm just happy we are leaving here safe."

"What arrangements did you make?"

Katie told her all that she discussed with the Doctor. "Maka, you didn't tell me other patients would be transferred along with the ones we recommended."

"It was Dr. Rigin's idea, not mine. Besides, I knew they wouldn't just want only four patients to be taken to the hospital."

"Yes, he told me that. I will go ahead and pack our stuff."

"I will help clean up," Amaka said sitting up on the bed.

"No, you don't have to lift a finger. I will pack our clothes and clean up the house. You just lie back and rest."

"I've been lying down all day. Okay, I will just sit up and watch you."

Amaka was feeling weaker than before but didn't want to make her friend anxious. She also needed to fight the sickness and not just lie down and feel sick. She sat up by sheer willpower and helped Katie do the packing.

## Chapter Twenty-Five

The driver of the Peugeot Station Wagon helped Katie load the bags in the trunk, and they boarded the vehicle. Doctor Rigin and the intern were on hand to see them off. There was no time to organize a farewell party. Katie and Amaka had said goodbye to the rest of the patients earlier and promised them they would come again sometime. The driver started the car, and they waved goodbye to the doctors as the driver drove off.

They arrived in Abuja late in the night and checked into a hotel.

The next morning Amaka went to a private clinic to see a doctor. While waiting for consultation with the doctor, she took in the differences in the practice of medicine in the USA and her home country. There was so much to do in the medical industry to bring it up to international standards. She was happy that she came to make an impact in her small way. She was thankful to God for giving her the strength and courage to come and to all the other people who have supported her so far, especially her friend Katie who sat beside her in the waiting room.

In a short while they were ushered into a doctor's office who greeted them warmly. He looked at the test results and the prescribed medication.

"Dr. Amaka how long have you been on this medication?"

"About two days. And I confess I didn't take the prescribed medication. I've been taking the drugs I came with."

"I would advise you to take the prescribed medication from Dr. Ringin. We know more about typhoid here than you do."

"I fear I might have a negative reaction from the prescribed drug because it might be too strong for me."

"Are you allergic to any of the ingredients in the drug?"

"I'm not sure."

"If you insist, you can continue with your own medicine for the next two days. If you get better fine, if you don't, you can come back and see me."

"Alright, I'm sure I will be fine."

"You will need to take some multivitamins too. Did you come with any?"

"Yes, vitamin C and the B complex family."

"I think that will do. Drink a lot of water and eat a lot of vegetables and fruits. I guess you know that already. And you need a lot of rest, that done, I think you will be up and about in no time."

"Thanks Doc."

"You will need to take another test a week after you finish taking the medicine. You need to be sure you are in the clear, the disease has to be eradicated, if not the bacteria start growing again."

"I don't think I will..."

"Okay Doctor, she will be back to take the test," Katie interjected. Amaka glanced at her friend and kept quiet. The doctor gave them a questioning look trying to figure out what Amaka wanted to say. Katie explained.

"We were supposed to travel to Enugu in three days, but I think it will be better if my friend gets the needed rest and confirmation test."

"I thought you are vacationing in Abuja."

"No, we came to do some work."

"Really?"

Katie briefed him on why they were in the country and the doctor was super impressed.

"You mean you came all the way from the States to another continent to offer help? That's amazing, what's your area of specialization?"

Katie answered the question for both.

"I see, I have a sister in the US who is about your age. She is a computer engineer. She lives in California."

"Oh wow, we are from the northeast, New Jersey to be precise."

"It's nice meeting you."

"Same here."

"Where are you staying in Abuja?"

"Nicon Noga Hotel."

"Okay, they do have the best intercontinental and nice vegetable dishes. If not, I would have taken you to someplace where you can order some nice meals."

"That's nice of you."

"Alright ladies, I will see you again, hopefully."

"You will, doctor, thanks."

"You are welcome."

They got up and left the doctor's office. Amaka turned to Katie as they walked towards the exit.

"Why did you tell the doctor I will come back in ten days to see him?"

"Because you need to rest, I think I would like to see him again."

## Chapter Twenty-Six

Aisha and Ekaete put their hold-all bags under the seats of the fifteen-seater bus that came to convey them and the other patients to the hospital in Abaka. They were accompanied by two nurses and a male doctor from the state Ministry of Health. Some of the patients were already seated. Ekaete was worried about the smell of urine which was already filling the bus. Some of the patient's cases were bad. It was one thing staying in a well-ventilated ward that was disinfected every three hours but an entirely different thing staying in a bus with limited ventilation. She had earlier secured a seat by the window by keeping her bag on the seat, Aisha sat next to her. She toyed with the idea of asking to sit in the front seat with the driver but knew she would be refused because she guessed the only other male traveling with them would sit there. Even if no male was accompanying them, the driver would still have refused a female sitting by him. She stood a little away from the bus until everybody boarded, she was the last person to board and the bus drove off. She wound down the windshield by her seat to allow air into the bus and put her nose to the window and tried to relax. She said a silent prayer as the bus picked up speed. Aisha sat next to her. She put her hands across the other in a hugging pose. She was already missing her baby. Her aunt had come the day before to take Laraba with her because the new hospital would not allow a baby in the hospital. She leaned back on the seat and glanced towards Ekaete who was focused on the view from the window. Aisha feared going to a place far away from anyone she knew. She tried not to let her fear overcome her. She looked at the faces on the bus, everyone was quiet, maybe they all felt the same as she did.

The patients from Goza VVF hospital arrived in Abaka late in the night and were admitted by the doctors and nurses on the night shift who were expecting them. They were all exhausted. The doctors did a ward round to find out if any of the patients had any complications due to the long travel, but none did. Aisha and Ekaete had their beds next to each other. Before long all of them were fast asleep. The nurses and

officials who brought them were taken to where they would spend the night.

Aisha woke up to the sound of a voice and slowly opened her eyes. She had slept like a log. Ekaete was already awake and listening to the nurse like the rest of the patients. The nurse spelled out to them the rules in the hospital. Ekaete raised her hand to call the nurse's attention.

"Yes, young lady, do you have a question?"

"Good morning nurse, my name is Ekaete. I want to let you know that most of the patients who came with me do not understand English. They will need somebody to translate what you are saying to them."

"That is true, would you do that for me?"

"No, my friend here can, she understands some English."

The nurse repeated her brief announcement which Aisha translated to the other patients.

The hospital in Abaka was bigger and more beautiful than that of Goza. It covered about three acres of land. The VVF unit was just a section of the hospital. Cherry flowers planted in clusters adorned the walkways and the entrance of every ward. There were several green areas where patients and visitors alike sit out to enjoy the clean clear air. There were trees everywhere.

Aisha, Eka, and a few of the patients were standing outside the entrance to their ward overlooking the well-kept green grass and flowers in front of them.

"I love this place. These flowers are beautiful. Aisha, we will take a tour of this hospital when we get well and can walk freely. And you know what? I wanted to study business administration at the university, maybe I should train to be a nurse or a doctor."

Aisha remained silent.

"What is wrong with you Aisha, you hardly talk these days. Are you alright? Okay, I get it, I think you are scared?"

"Yes, Eka I'm scared of this place, I'm scared of the surg, surg."

"Surgery."

"Yes, Surgery."

"You don't have to be afraid. You should be happy instead. You should be happy that soon you will be well and be able to live normally again."



“Why doctor is not here?”

“Doctor will be here soon. They will not carry out the surgery until she comes, so there’s no need to be afraid.”

With that assurance, Aisha tried to relax. Ekaete grabbed her hand “Let’s walk to the end of this building and see what is on the other side.”

They ventured to the end of the building and looked around. All the buildings looked alike. One can only differentiate the wards by the names on the wall. Eka realized that one could easily miss the way and walk into another ward. They stood there for a few minutes watching the nurses and doctors and some of the people who were looking after their relations. She suddenly felt lonely. How different it would have been if her mother or sibling were here to look after her. Her mother does not even know she has VVF. Her siblings probably didn’t have a clue she was in the hospital right now. She glanced at Aisha and saw the sadness in her eyes, and she understood how lost Aisha must be feeling too. She put her arm on Aisha’s shoulder and they walked back to their ward in silence.

## Chapter Twenty-Seven

Meimuna disembarked from the bus she boarded from Abuja to Abaka and walked towards the back of the bus to pick up her bags. She kept glancing over her shoulder to be sure the lady who promised to show her the way to the hospital doesn't get out of her sight. She turned towards the woman.

"Where you say I go get bus to the aspital?"

"Eh, aspital, the hospital, don't worry, I will go with you, I will take you there before going to my house."

"Thanks you ma."

"Come with me, we will take a tricycle along the road."

Meimuna walked faster to catch up with the young lady, the bag of fruits in her right hand slowed her pace. She tried to balance the bag on her left shoulder from time to time until they came to where they boarded the tricycle which was quite some distance from the bus stop. By the time they reached the hospital, dusk was setting in. Meimuna worried if they would allow her to see Aisha and more so if they would allow her to stay with her.

At the reception, her worry was dispelled as the young lady who escorted her helped explain to the receptionist who she was and the patient she wanted to see. After a little fuss, an auxiliary nurse led her to Aisha's ward.

"Auntie Meimuna!" Aisha shouted as she saw her aunty walk through the door. She hurried to hug her as everybody turned to stare at the visitor.

"Auntie Meimuna, you came to see me? She asked again and again.

"How are you, Aisha?"

"I'm fine. Come, come and sit down." She took her hand and led her towards her bed.

"How are Laraba, Zainab and Yakubu, all of them, who did you leave the children with?"

"Aisha, give your aunty space to settle down first before bombarding her with questions."

"Aunty this is my friend Eka." She introduced both as Meimuna sat down.

"Welcome once again Aunty. How did you get here and how was your journey?"

"It went well, Aisha. I asked around how I could get a bus to this place, and I was directed to the bus terminal in Abuja. On the bus, I asked the driver how I could get to this hospital, and a young lady seating close to me offered to show me the way, but later came with me. She was God sent.

"That's very kind of her."

"Walahi Aisha this is a big hospital; I would have gotten lost coming here on my own."

"Yes, it is big; you have only seen a quarter of the hospital grounds."

"Where is Dectar Amaka, is her house far away?"

"She is making final arrangements for our surgery; we have not seen her since we came here."

"Does that mean you still have a long time to stay here?"

"She will be back soon, why?"

"I can only stay for one week, that's how long my husband said I can stay."

"Oh, aunty you came to look after me, I thought you only came to visit. One week is long enough whether she comes back while you are here or not."

Meimuna could see her niece's vivacity was back. The gloomy look in her eyes has been replaced with the familiar gleam she knew and that made her happy. She started answering Aisha's questions one after the other.

## Chapter Twenty-Eight

Amaka and Katie arrived at Enugu International Airport in the company of three other medical volunteers. They had sent some hospital equipment to the hospital in advance. They were received at the airport by two doctors from the Hospital in Abaka who accompanied them to the Hospital. After the necessary introductions and paperwork, they were taken to their living quarters.

After unpacking, they went in search of Aisha and Eka, they were overjoyed to see them after three long weeks. They got a bear hug from each of them. Meimuna got up to greet them too. Aisha introduced her aunt to the doctors.

"I'm happy to meet you. It is nice of you to come and visit your niece."

"Thank you, Decter."

"I can see that is why Aisha is so happy." She turned to Aisha and Eka.

"Girls, I hope you are ready, you will have your surgery in less than a week."

The two girls exchanged looks.

"I hope you are not scared, there's nothing to be afraid of, you will be fine and soon you will be able to go back home and continue with your life."

"How soon are we having the surgery?"

"That should be in about three or four days Eka."

"That means it will take place while Aunty Meimuna is here. That is great, at least there is somebody to look after us."

"Eka, do you want me to call Grace? She has been asking after you."

"No doctor, I would rather you call her after the surgery. It will be better when I have some good news to tell her."

"Alright girls, we are going to finish unpacking, the next time we see, it will be in the theatre because I'm going to be busy. Be sure to do whatever the doctors and nurses ask you to do, it is very important for the success of your surgery."

"We might see them one more time in the company of the other doctors, don't you think Katie?"

"It may or may not be necessary, we will see."

"Okay, and do not forget to pray, you need God's help."

"We will, thank you."

Amaka and Katie had a few words with the other patients from Goza and left.

Amaka and her team of doctors with the help of urologists and gynaecologists at the Abaka hospital carried out fistula fixtures on twenty-four patients during their two weeks stay at the hospital. Aisha, Eka, and the ten others from Goza were among the first twelve.

The girls stayed for two weeks before they could go home and finish recuperating. Meimuna stayed back to look after them and Grace and Fred promised to come and pick up Eka to bring her back to her parents. On the eve of her departure back to the United States, Amaka came to visit them.

"Now tell me Aisha, what are your plans when you leave this hospital."

"I will go with Auntie Memuna, I will go to school, I will become a nurse."

"That is good. Meimuna will you be able to protect Aisha from being forced to go back to her husband?"

"Me I no tell Aisha's husband she don well until she go school."

"She means she will keep Aisha's recovery from her family members until she completes her education." Eka explained to Amaka.

"That will be difficult, how are you going to keep her recovery a secret?"

"Me, I won't go home," Aisha said firmly, shaking her index finger for emphasis.

"I will call and ask my oga to help us." Meimuna reiterated.

"Me, I no marry Mallam Shehu again," Aisha said again in a determined tone. Amaka left it at that and turned to Eka.

"What about you Eka, I guess you have learned your lesson."

"Yes Doctor, I will finish my senior secondary school and study medicine."

"I believe you can do that. Promise me you will stand by your decision, and help Aisha complete her education."

"I promise doctor. We will not let your efforts be in vain."

“One more thing, as soon as you go back to Abuja, go to a bank and open an account and give me the details of the account. I will send your school fees to the account until you can support yourself.”

“I will do that, thank you doctor, God bless you.”

“Tomorrow, I will see you off to the bus park and I will be on my way to Abuja to board a flight back to the United States. Here’s my phone number and email address.”

Amaka gave Eka the piece of paper. Eka’s eyes lit up in excitement.

“Be sure to get enough rest and take your drugs religiously so that you will be strong as quickly as possible.”

“Thank you doctor.” Meimuna got up from the bed and knelt to show her appreciation. Aisha made to do the same.

“Please stand up, you don’t have to do that Aisha, you will hurt yourself.” Amaka held her up before she could kneel.

“We will call you via Zoom anytime we can get together. You should go to sleep now so you can wake up early tomorrow.”

Eka stood up and hugged her. “Goodnight doctor.”

“Goodnight.”

Aisha walked hesitantly toward Amaka and hugged her as well

Six months later, Ekaete enrolled to finish her junior secondary school at Karu government secondary school. She was on time to enrol for junior WAEC, and though she had a shorter time to study for the examination, she knew she could pass the exam. Her school had a computer centre and she started learning to use the computer and how to get on the internet, she could send emails to Amaka and Zolan. She had gone to see Aisha twice. Aisha had to wait till the beginning of another school year to enrol in junior secondary school.

## EPILOGUE

All the students at Girls Secondary School Mando were seated in the main auditorium of the school. The Master of Ceremony introduced the special guests of the occasion and the two young girls amongst them. The President of Right Choice Network who initiated the program gave a summary of the subject of the day. At the end of her speech, she called the two girls in her entourage to the podium.

Aisha and Ekaete mounted the podium. They had practiced reading the script together for two weeks. Aisha's legs were shaking so much she thought she would pass out. She remembered what their trainer told them and took three deep breaths and tried to relax. Ekaete did the same and started her address without looking at the script.

"My name is Ekaete Udoh, and the name of my friend here is Aisha Gambo, we are both survivors of Vesical Vaginal Fistula called VVF for short. Before we tell our story, I would like to know how many of you know about VVF."

Ekaete counted the hands that were raised.

"The hands that are up are fewer than those down, which means fewer people know about VVF. I'm here to tell you all I know about VVF; Its causes, its cure, and how it can be avoided or prevented."

Aisha admired Ekaete's composure, she was not even reading the script. She tried to look composed as well. All the girls in the auditorium looked up at Ekaete with increasing interest. Some of them were about her age, some were younger.

"I will start by telling my story. I was sent to be a housemaid at the age of fifteen, I was barely sixteen before I got pregnant. I knew little to nothing about pregnancy or the responsibility that came with it. I was home alone close to the time of delivery, I had protracted labour and I fell while trying to get help, all these caused a tear in my urinary tract wall and resulted in what is known as VVF."

"VVF occurs when the unborn child presses on the pelvis for a long time and causes a hole somewhere between the walls of the uterus and the bladder."

Eka didn't quite know how to put the definition into words, without being embarrassed.

"During an interview on NTA program on Health Matters, Dr. Eyika said 'When girls are under eighteen years of age, their pelvis is not properly developed. The pelvis is still growing, which means that the hip bone is not yet quite ready to push a baby through it. This causes prolonged labour' which leads to this condition."

"Also, in the Nigerian Health Journal, it is reported that more young girls suffer from the disease, though scientists cannot explain why it is more prevalent now than before. Doctors are still trying to figure out why it is so."

"Young girls like us should know everything about VVF so that we don't become victims."

"VVF has many psychological implications. Number one, the people close to you will be ashamed of you, your friends would not like to come near you, you cannot go out freely like other young girls because you will be smelling of urine all the time. If you are married, your husband will reject you. You will be in Isolation, all alone with your baby and chances are that you might suffer from depression and not care for your baby."

"Many of you may be wondering if VVF can be cured. The answer is yes, it can be cured. The cure for VVF is called fistula fixture. When you hear doctors talk about fistula fixture, it is the term used for the cure of VVF. I got cured and my friend Aisha got cured too."

"VVF cure requires a specialized kind of surgery performed by gynaecologists, urologists, and expert surgeons. This surgery is expensive which is why young girls should avoid having VVF."

Ekaete paused to catch her breath. She observed the faces of the students to know if they were interested in what she was saying and saw rapt attention, she continued her lecture.

"When we know about VVF, we can decide not to ever have it. As I said earlier, young girls are advised not to marry too early or young girls should not have children early. Doctors say that the maximum development of a woman's reproductive organs occurs from the age of twenty. So, we should avoid having children before that age."



“If you get pregnant before the age of twenty, make sure that you have quality antenatal care. That means you should go to the hospital regularly so that the doctor can examine you. If the doctor sees that you will have problems with normal delivery, he or she will recommend an alternative means of delivery so that you do not have VVF.”

“Again, do not go to local uneducated midwives who will give you incisions with unsterilized instruments and damage your bladder.”

Aisha’s eyes darted around the hall, and she started fidgeting again because she will soon have to translate all that Ekaete has said to Hausa. She started deep breathing. Ekaete continued her address.

“Girls should support other girls who have VVF and not stay away from them. If you have any questions, please write them down, there will be a question-and-answer session after Aisha translates what I have said in Hausa. It will also be translated into Igbo and Yoruba. Thank you for listening.”

The attentive audience clapped for her with a standing ovation.

Aisha took the microphone which Ekaete handed over to her and translated all that Ekaete said in Hausa. At the end of her speech, the students gave them standing ovation. The director of Right Choice Network took the microphone and reiterated what the two VVF survivors said and answered the questions from some members of the audience. She announced that there will be an annual enlightenment program on VVF.

Aisha, a young girl with lofty dreams, is forced to marry a man older than her father and her desire for education is shattered. She experiences a life altering ailment during childbirth which sends her to a long stay in the hospital. At the hospital she makes friends with Eka and through chance and technology they get connected to another girl in another continent who sets in motion events that help them overcome their health challenges and change the trajectory of their lives.

#### ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Ihuoma Iroaga is a graduate of English and Literary Studies from the University of Calabar and Mass Communication from Liberty University, Lynchburg Virginia. She has written several other novels, *On The Trail To Freedom, Hunt For The Golden Pen, The King's Wife, and Gana's Moonlight Tales*.



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